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INSIDE



Musician's death: Rijiju, Manipur CM seek action

NEW DELHI
Union Minister Kiren Rijiju and Manipur Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh on Tuesday called for swift and strict action against those responsible for the killing of Manipuri music teacher Chongtham Vikram Singh in Delhi. Congress leaders Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi raised concerns over the safety of people from the Northeast in Delhi. » PAGE 6

BJP leaders shun veg-food 'diktat' for Durga Puja

KOLKATA
West Bengal BJP leaders came out in support of party State unit president Samik Bhattacharya who said Bengalis would eat fish and meat during Durga Puja. Rejecting the advice of Bageshwar Dham chief priest Dharendra Krishna Shastri to follow a vegetarian diet, they said outsiders "won't understand our culture" and there was a tradition of animal sacrifices. » PAGE 2

Judge awards 23 death penalties in five months

NEW DELHI
Stating that he would rather "die" than be labelled a "coward", Muzaffarnagar additional district and sessions judge Ravi Kumar Diwakar, who has handed down 22 death sentences in the past five months, awarded another death sentence on Monday in a dowry-murder case. The judge was in the spotlight earlier after allowing a survey of the Gyanvapi mosque premises in Varanasi in 2022. » PAGE 6

PM slams critics as he opens freight corridor

PM inaugurates key sections of Dedicated Freight Corridor connecting U.P. to port in Navi Mumbai | He dismisses Rahul's campaign against his govt. as an 'echo of lies', attempt to mislead the youth | Modi says his opponents will continue to find fault with 'major infrastructure milestones'

Press Trust of India VADODARA

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday took a dig at the Opposition over a newly inaugurated dedicated freight corridor, saying critics would still complain like a "naraz fufa" (grumpy uncle) and manufacture grievances, while dismissing Congress leader Rahul Gandhi's campaign against the government as "jhooth ki goonj" (echo of lies).

Speaking at the inauguration of three key sections of the Western Dedicated Freight Corridor, connecting Jawaharlal Nehru Port in Navi Mumbai with Dadri in Uttar Pradesh, and marking the project's completion, Mr. Modi praised his administration's pace of execution and called the former UPA regime's working speed "sluggish".

"After 2014, with your blessings, when I reached Delhi, and as soon as we arrived there, we began ac-

celerating this project. Work on the dedicated freight corridor has been completed today," he said.

The "jhooth ki goonj" jibe appeared to mock the *Chhatron Ki Goonj* student dialogue campaign launched by the Congress. Through the campaign, the Congress is trying to corner the BJP on issues such as exam question paper leaks, costly education, irregularities in government recruitment and unemployment.

'Finding fault'

Targeting Mr. Gandhi without naming him, Mr. Modi said opponents would always find fault with major infrastructure milestones such as the newly inaugurated freight corridor.

"Now, the *naraz fufa ji* (grumpy uncle) will start shouting: What will happen to the truck drivers? Where will the trucks go? What about the trucks people have purchased? Now, *fufa ji* has found something



Grand welcome: Prime Minister Narendra Modi at the event in Vadodara on Tuesday. PMO

new to complain about," the Prime Minister said.

He pointed to "rapid modernisation" under his decade-long tenure compared to the previous administration's shortcomings.

"After 2014, India built 50,000 modern rail coaches. The previous regime could not build even

50,000 toilets in 10 years," he said.

Taking aim at the Opposition's youth outreach efforts, specifically Mr. Gandhi's *Chhatron Ki Goonj* campaign in Pune last month, the Prime Minister cautioned the youth against "falling for political misdirection".

"At every nook and cor-

ner, you will find people who will try to mislead you through lies, but today's youth will stand with the truth," Mr. Modi said, urging youngsters to align with factual progress over political narrative.

He said the youth could see how focused the government was on working across sectors, including

solar, wind, hydro, and nuclear energy. Describing the dedicated railway freight corridor as the life-line of a rapidly developing nation, the Prime Minister noted that India's economic transformation was accelerating due to the modern freight structure. Earlier, passenger and goods trains were forced to run on the same tracks, which severely hampered both passenger travel and freight movement, but the dedicated corridor altered that dynamic, he said.

Criticising the administrative delays under the previous government, he pointed out that though the concept originated in 2004 and a special purpose vehicle was set up in 2006, files remained stuck without progress until 2014.

"Unfortunately, even these files were not fortunate enough to get a dedicated corridor. Files would get stuck, hang around, wander aimlessly," Mr. Mo-

di said. India is scripting a new saga of manufacturing, spanning "chips to ships", with components, final products and the supply chain for self-reliance being set up in the country, Mr. Modi said.

At an event in Mumbai later in the day, Mr. Modi said the Indian economy's 7.8% real GDP expansion gave confidence to the world at large because the performance came in a challenging quarter when the impact of the West Asia conflict was the highest.

He said India had emerged as a major manufacturer of railway coaches, metro coaches and locomotives in the last decade.

A 100-km journey that earlier took 6.5 hours for a freight train can now be covered in less than half the time, while a 30-hour journey by truck can be completed in 10-12 hours on the Dedicated Freight Corridor, the Prime Minister noted.

Fish out of water



A fish-shaped booth installed on the walkway to encourage people to throw plastic bottles into it, rather than in the backwaters, lies empty in Ernakulam, Kerala. The installation aims to raise awareness about the growing menace of plastic waste in water bodies. R.K. NITHIN

SC mulls pan-India safety rules for student hostels

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Tuesday indicated that it may expand its court-monitored exercise against illegal constructions and unauthorised use of residential premises to examine the safety of student accommodations across the country.

It comes days after seven people were killed in the collapse of an illegally constructed building being used as a paying guest (PG) facility in Delhi.

A Bench said it would take up the matter on Thursday after the court-appointed *amicus curiae* sought a time-bound safety audit of PG facilities, private hostels and other accommodations in and around colleges across Delhi. Senior advocate Ajit Kumar Sinha, the court-appointed *amicus curiae*, told the Bench that he had filed a fresh status report following the Satya Niketan building collapse.

The report, he said, raised "serious concerns" over existing mechanisms for inspecting buildings, identifying dangerous structures and enforcing building bylaws.



The *amicus curiae* sought a audit of PG facilities, private hostels and other accommodations in Delhi. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

action taken against similar violations.

On Tuesday, the Bench of Justices Ahsanuddin Amanullah and R. Mahadevan also turned down an oral request by Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Centre, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) and the Delhi Police, to allow the Delhi High Court to separately continue hearing a petition seeking a comprehensive probe into the Satya Niketan incident. The High Court had on Monday ordered an inquiry into the tragedy and a safety inspection of PG facilities under the MCD's jurisdiction.

"No. This might have been taken up in the right earnest, but it is overlapping. We will take it up. We already have something in mind... It has to be on a pan-India basis," Justice Amanullah orally remarked.

While Mr. Mehta acknowledged that it was a "horrific" tragedy and that families were grieving the loss of lives, particularly of children, he pointed out that the High Court was already cognisant of the incident and had taken it up

"in the right earnest". The Bench, however, said it would take up the matter on Thursday and indicated that it could thereafter consider transferring the proceedings pending before the High Court to itself.

Safety audit sought

The latest status report, filed through advocate-on-record Govind Jee, pointed out that while the Supreme Court had already constituted a committee to inspect buildings in Lajpat Nagar, Saket, and Malviya Nagar, Satya Niketan did not fall within the scope of the exercise.

It also referred to a building collapse in Satya Niketan in April 2022, which killed two people and injured four. The recurrence of a fatal collapse in the same locality, the report said, raised concerns over the effectiveness of inspection mechanisms.

The report accordingly urged the court to extend monitoring across Delhi, particularly to student accommodation around universities and colleges.

EDITORIAL
» PAGE 8

Saudi oil facilities on fire after Houthi attacks

Associated Press
CAIRO

The Houthi rebel group in Yemen launched a wave of attacks on Saudi Arabia on Tuesday, wounding more than 70 people and igniting fires at oil facilities and utilities in the kingdom, authorities said.

Weeks of clashes have added pressure to limited global oil supplies as the Houthis target a shipping route Saudi Arabia has used to transport oil to world markets while the Strait of Hormuz is throttled by the U.S.-Iran war. Tuesday's attacks hit Saudi oil facilities connected to an alternative route, the Bab el-Mandeb, a strategic waterway off the southern tip of the Arabian Peninsula that connects the Red Sea to the Gulf of Aden.



Smoke rising from the Saudi Aramco oil depot, after reported attacks by Houthis, in Abha Bulk, Saudi Arabia, on Tuesday. REUTERS

The attacks came hours after the rebels blamed Saudi Arabia for an air strike that hit a prison in Yemen's northern province of Jawf. At least seven people, including a child, were killed and seven others were wounded.

The rebels hit "civilian and economic facilities" in the Saudi cities of Abha, Ja-

zan, Najran and Khamis Mushait, said Major General Turki al-Malki, a spokesperson for the Saudi-led coalition fighting in Yemen.

Seventy-three people were wounded, including women and children, he said, calling the attacks a "serious escalation" and vowing retaliation.

The Houthi attacks ignited fires at several oil facilities and utilities in Saudi Arabia's southern region, the kingdom's Energy Ministry said, adding that operations at the oil facilities and utilities were temporarily suspended.

The southern region houses major oil facilities, including a 4,00,000-barrel-per-day oil refinery in Jazan, which is one of Saudi Arabia's largest. The Houthis previously attacked the Abha airport.

The Ministry said firefighters were battling the fires on Tuesday morning.

Saudi retaliation

Later, the Houthis said Saudi Arabia retaliated with strikes. "Saudi aggression" hit Taiz province, where deadly fighting has raged for days, and Marib

province, the Houthis' *Al-masirah* TV station said.

In a recorded video statement, Brig. Gen. Yahya Saree, the Houthis military spokesman, said they fired dozens of ballistic missiles and drones at oil and economic facilities, as well as an air base in southern Saudi Arabia.

He said they targeted Jazan City for Primary and Downstream Industries, a major industrial and logistics hub on Saudi Arabia's southwestern Red Sea coast. The rebels also aimed at Aramco facilities in Najran and Abha, as well as King Khalid Air Base in Khamis Mushait.

Mr. Saree blamed Saudi Arabia for the escalation, warning that "every aggression against our country and people will be met with a firm response."

INBRIEF



BJP launches four-day protest in Jharkhand over exam row

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in Jharkhand on Tuesday launched a four-day Statewide protest demanding the withdrawal of cases against students protesting alleged irregularities in recruitment examinations and a probe by the Central Bureau of Investigation. State BJP president Aditya Sahu led a protest outside the Ranchi Deputy Commissioner's office, while Leader of the Opposition Babul Marandi protested in Dumka and former Chief Ministers Raghubar Das and Madhu Koda in Hazaribagh and Jamshedpur respectively. They alleged that the government is suppressing the students' protests.

Gehlot alleges ₹900-crore dues to gaushalas pending

Former Rajasthan Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot on Tuesday alleged that ₹900 crore in grants to 4,523 gaushalas housing 18 lakh cattle had been pending for 10 months, forcing operators to borrow and rely on donations for fodder. Mr. Gehlot accused the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) of neglecting cattle welfare. He warned that drought-like conditions could worsen the situation. He alleged that farmers were selling produce below the minimum support price (MSP) or waiting months for payments, and accused the BJP of coming to power by "misleading" farmers despite the Congress's 2023 promise of an MSP guarantee law. PTI

Bengal's BJP leaders oppose appeal for vegetarian *pujo* amid Oppn. fire

Ministers Agnimitra Paul, Dilip Ghosh, Tapas Roy defend people's right to 'eat what they want' after clarification by West Bengal unit chief Samik Bhattacharya; Oppn. takes on BJP over appeal by 'godman' to keep meat away during Durga Puja

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Several Ministers and senior Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leaders in West Bengal on Tuesday backed State party chief Samik Bhattacharya's rejection of the appeal by Bageshwar Dham chief priest Dharendra Krishna Shastri to keep non-vegetarian food away from Durga Puja pandals.

The statements by ruling party leaders, including Urban Development Minister Agnimitra Paul, Panchayat Minister and former State unit chief Dilip Ghosh, and BJP veteran and former Tripura Governor Tathagata Roy, came on a day when the Opposition tried to corner the government over the issue.

'CM must clarify'

While the Congress lodged a police complaint against Mr. Shastri, Trinamool Congress MLA Kunal Ghosh sought a clarification from Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari, who had welcomed Mr. Shastri.

"This is not just a matter of filing a complaint. The government is patronising



Congress activists staging a protest outside the Bhowanipur police station against 'godman' Dharendra Krishna Shastri on Tuesday. PTI

all this. Friends of this government come and insult Bengal and Bengalis whenever they wish," he said.

CPI(M) leader Bikash Ranjan Bhattacharya said the Bageshwar Dham chief priest was not to be blamed for the controversy, but those who had invited him to Bengal.

'A different culture'

Ms. Paul, the Urban Development Minister, said, "Our State party president has clearly said that any

person coming from outside will not understand our culture. In other States, people have vegetarian meals during Durga Puja. Here, we save money so that we can have mutton and fish."

The former State BJP president said there is a tradition of offering animal sacrifice during Durga Puja and Kali Puja, and meat is offered as 'prasad'. Industries Minister Tapas Roy said, "Each religion has its own rules but people will

eat whatever they want."

Mr. Shastri's appeal on September 6 during his two-day visit to Kolkata had prompted criticism of the BJP, which had sought to convince the electorate during the Assembly poll campaign earlier this year that it was not in favour of imposing vegetarianism.

Damage control

On Monday, Mr. Bhattacharya attempted damage control by asserting that "nobody can ask Bengalis to give up non-vegetarian food". Despite their opposition to Mr. Shastri's appeal, none of the BJP leaders have directly criticised the 'godman', saying there is nothing wrong with promoting vegetarianism.

Sanjeev Sanyal, a member of Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister, also weighed in on the issue. In an X post on Monday, he stated: "Meat is core to Shakta Hinduism. It is offered to Maa Durga and Maa Kali as part of the ancient rituals. The prasad eaten by the devotees on Navami/Dasami at Durga Puja is meat. Any interference in this sacred ritual will not be tolerated."

Congress files complaints over Shastri's remarks

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

Congress leaders in West Bengal on Tuesday filed complaints against Dhendra Krishna Shastri over remarks on food habits during Durga Puja, alleging that they had hurt Bengali sentiments.

South Kolkata District Congress Committee president Pradip Prasad lodged a complaint at Bhowanipur police station. Party workers also protested outside the station demanding an FIR.

Similar complaints were filed at Muchipara police station and, according to the party, across the State.

"Bengali culture, lifestyle, eating habits, or religious practices, or who we believe in, or who we pray to cannot be dictated by a godman like him," said Suman Roy Chaudhuri, a senior Congress leader.

'Drop Open Column for Backward Classes, others in Census 2027'

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu Assembly on Tuesday unanimously adopted a resolution urging the Centre to pre-load the lists of Backward Classes (BCs), Most Backward Classes (MBCs), and Denotified Communities (DNCs), notified by the Central and State governments, on the census portal/application so as to collect the caste details in the second phase of Census 2027 only on the basis of the names contained therein.

It urged the Centre to enumerate the BCs, the MBCs, and the DNCs in the same manner as the Scheduled Castes (SCs) and the Scheduled Tribes (STs) and dispense with the ambiguous Open-Column Method. Under this, respondents can self-declare their castes, which the enumerator will record, instead of choosing one from a predefined list. The resolution, moved by Minister for Backward Classes Welfare V. Sampathkumar, said it was essential to gather accurate details based on the lists of BCs, MBCs, and DNCs notified by the Central and State governments. All the members backed the resolution.

Top court bars Assam from appointing private school teachers under 2017 law

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Tuesday directed the Assam government not to appoint or absorb teachers in schools and colleges under a 2017 State law unless they possess the qualifications prescribed under Central laws.

The Assam Education (Provincialisation of Services of Teachers and Re-Organisation of Educational Institutions) Act, 2017, allows teachers of non-government institutions to be absorbed into government service.

A Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant passed the interim order while hearing a peti-

The Bench headed by Chief Justice of India warned that appointment of 'unqualified' teachers would destroy the future generations

tion by Rajesh Chauhan and Madhab Mukunda Pujari challenging the law for allegedly allowing unqualified private school teachers into government service without meeting requirements under Central laws.

"Why are they appointing unqualified teachers?... We will destroy our future generations if this is permitted," the Bench remarked.

The court issued notice to the Centre, the Assam government and State education authorities and sought their responses on the petition.

Senior advocate Ranjit Kumar, for the petitioners, argued that the law allowed private school teachers to enter government service without open advertisement, competitive selection or merit-based assessment.

"They are now calling them tutors... the quality of education is suffering," he said.

The petitioners said this violated Articles 14 and 16 of the Constitution and sought a review of those provincialised under the 2011 and 2017 laws.

BJP, Congress corner AAP govt. in Punjab over 'failure' to curb drug crisis after villager's death

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH/NEW DELHI

The heated debate over Punjab's drug crisis reached a boiling point on Tuesday with the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the Congress targeting the ruling Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) following the alleged suicide of a villager, who was reportedly under pressure to apologise for questioning Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema over the unabated supply of *chitta* (synthetic drugs) in the State.

Gulzar Singh, a 47-year-old Dalit villager from Dirba in Sangrur district, was found dead on Monday. His family said he had questioned Mr. Cheema about the supply of drugs in the area during an event in Dirba the day before.

Punjab BJP president Ke-



Police personnel use water cannons to disperse Congress leaders staging a protest in Chandigarh on Tuesday. PTI

wal Singh Dhillon claimed that in a video purportedly recorded before Gulzar Singh's death, he named the Finance Minister and others and allegedly held them responsible for the circumstances leading to his "suicide". Mr. Dhillon led a delegation to meet Governor Gulab Chand Kataria and submitted a mem-

orandum seeking immediate action into the incident. The party demanded that the case should not be treated merely as a suicide case and that the allegations should be thoroughly investigated in accordance with law.

In Delhi, BJP spokesperson Gaurav Bhatia accused the Punjab government of

inaction on the issue of growing drug abuse. Mr. Bhatia alleged that Gulzar Singh was threatened and harassed following which he made a video holding four persons responsible for his situation. Arguing that the video was a "dying declaration", the BJP leader sought action under the SC/ST Act and the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, along with the resignation of Mr. Mann and Mr. Cheema.

Congress general secretary in-charge of communications Jairam Ramesh said people are watching everything and every act of oppression and arrogance will have to be accounted for. "The terrifying and utterly shameful face of the AAP government in Punjab! Gulzar Singh, who expressed the agony of his son ruined by drugs (*chitta*) and openly questioned Fi-

nance Minister Harpal Cheema about the rampant sale of drugs, was forced to take his own life," he wrote on X.

Mann's effigy burnt

Punjab Congress leaders and workers held a demonstration against the AAP government and demanded the resignation of the Chief Minister and the State Finance Minister. Led by Punjab chief Amrinder Singh Raja Warring, the leaders held a protest outside the Congress office in Chandigarh and burnt the effigy of Mr. Mann. Police used water cannon to disperse the protesters who were trying to proceed towards the Chief Minister's residence to 'gherao' it.

With inputs from PTI
(Those in distress can dial Tele MANAS helpline at 14416)

SP-RLD row over 'chavanni' flips open caste fault lines in U.P.

NEWS ANALYSIS

Anuj Kumar
GHAZIABAD

The modest *chavanni* - the now-obsolete 25-paise coin - is gaining currency in western Uttar Pradesh ahead of the State election following a war of words over loyalty and caste identity between Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD) president Jayant Chaudhary and his former ally, Samajwadi Party (SP) chief Akhilesh Yadav. The conflict escalated after Mr. Yadav made a veiled jibe targeting Mr. Chaudhary. "We turned a *chavanni* into a rupee, and yet they left us," the SP chief said at a recent event in Lucknow. This was a direct reference to Mr. Chaudhary's own famous 2022 declaration, when he resisted Bharatiya Janata Party's (BJP) initial overtures during the 2022 poll by saying, "I am not a *chavanni* that will flip."

After subsequently flip-

ping to join the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) before the 2024 Lok Sabha election, Mr. Chaudhary became a target for the Opposition. At the time, he defended the move because the BJP-led government conferred the Bharat Ratna on former Prime Minister and his grandfather, Chaudhary Charan Singh, before the poll.

Jat loyalties in the region are broadly governed by farming issues, respect for Mr. Chaudhary's family and Hindutva, and perhaps that's why Mr. Chaudhary explained his political switch to the electorate during the Lok Sabha poll with a cryptic line, "*Main palta nahin hoon, maine palti di hai, ise patakni marna kehne hain* (I didn't turn my back or betray anyone; I executed a political move to slam my political rivals)." The Jats read it in two ways. Those nursing a grudge against Mulayam Singh Yadav - for betraying the trust of his mentor Charan Singh



Poll position: Former allies RLD chief Jayant Chaudhary and SP president Akhilesh Yadav. FILE PHOTO

and scuttling his son Ajit Singh's chances of becoming U.P.'s Chief Minister after the Janata Dal came to power in December 1989 - saw Mr. Chaudhary's flip to the BJP as a perfect move. And farmers who questioned the silence of the BJP's Jat face, Sanjeev Balyan, during the farm agitation saw it as a strategic manoeuvre to reclaim Jat politics from the BJP while remaining in the NDA fold.

Two years later, the ground has shifted. In SP's narrative, Mr. Chaudhary is

in the Rajya Sabha because of its largesse and should have resigned when the RLD joined the NDA. The breakdown happened over the number of seats, but SP sympathisers underline that the BJP left only two seats for RLD in the Lok Sabha poll while the SP was ready to give five more. Out of nine MLAs, RLD has two Muslim MLAs in the Jat belt, and the SP seems keen to win them and their community support base. The party is also reaching out to Gurjars to make a choice.

Despite joining hands with the BJP, Mr. Chaudhary hasn't given up on his *bhaichara* plank, but the current friction will make it difficult for him to hold on to it. It is favourable for the BJP as it will help it polarise the election. For, after RLD's rise in 2022, Muslim farmers once again saw Jats as their shield.

There is a section in the ruling party that feels that the tie-up with the RLD didn't help, as the INDIA bloc secured six of the eight seats in the heart of the sugarcane belt in 2024. Many others feel the BJP bought peace at the U.P. border by aligning with RLD because the Jat farmers had packed their lathis and parked their tractors off the National Highway 9. In its recently constituted Parliamentary Board, RLD has included Yudhvir Singh, farmer leader and the general secretary of the Tikait faction of the Bharatiya Kisan Union, as a special invitee.

RLD insiders believe the

party stemmed the impending disaster from the BJP's internal fight and is seeking a bigger slice of the pie. With the SP, RLD contested 33 Assembly seats. It helps that the Jats are agitated against the SP.

Political observers feel after resisting for a long time, Mr. Chaudhary had to bow to the demands of his vote bank, which saw the community's future with the BJP after the Muzaffarnagar riots. But after two years in government, where he is Minister of State for Education, the same section, which didn't support him enough when he led protests against Agniveer recruitment, is questioning his silence on Gen-Z protests. The murder of Haryana singer Ankit Balyan in Shamli is seen as another provocation for him to get into 'action' mode.

The big question now is whether Mr. Chaudhary will shed the *chavanni* tag by making the BJP cede seats worth a rupee for him.

Jarange accuses govt. of 'deceiving' Marathas; calls meet on Sept. 12

Press Trust of India
JALNA

Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange-Patil on Tuesday accused Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis and Minister Radhakrishna Vikhe Patil of deceiving the community on the reservation issue for over a year.

As his health deteriorated on the 11th day of his indefinite hunger strike at Antarwali Sarati in Jalna, Mr. Jarange was administered intravenous fluids after suffering severe dehydration.

He has been demanding reservation for Marathas under the Other Backward Classes category, including implementation of the Hyderabad and Satara Gazette records and issuance of Kunbi caste certificates

to eligible members of the community. Mr. Jarange questioned Mr. Fadnavis over his earlier promise to provide reservation based on the Hyderabad Gazette within two months and accused Mr. Vikhe Patil of having "deceived the Maratha community".

He urged Marathas from Pune, Thane, Nashik and Mumbai to gather at Antarwali Sarati on September 12 to decide the agitation's future course.

Mr. Vikhe Patil said the government had acted on all issues raised by Mr. Jarange and urged him to "take two steps forward".

Mr. Fadnavis said the government would grant whatever was permissible under the Constitution but "would not take from one community's share to give another".



ED writes to police; seeks FIR against Pinarayi, daughter

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has sent a detailed report to the State Police Chief seeking registration of a separate first information report (FIR) under the Prevention of Corruption Act and other relevant laws against Leader of the Opposition and former Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, former Minister P.A. Mohamed Riyas, and T. Veena, Mr. Vijayan's daughter and Mr. Riyas' spouse, in the Exalogic-Cochin Minerals and Rutile Limited (CMRL) pay-off case.

The report, which was sent on Monday reportedly stated that the evidence recovered by the Central agency in the case under Section 66(2) of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) warranted registration of a case.

The CPI(M) has been on a collision course with the ED, accusing the agency of carrying out a political hit job targeting Mr. Vijayan and his family on behalf of the Central government.

Sources in the ED said it would carry out a thorough investigation once an FIR has been registered.

Charges in ED report

The report accused Mr. Vijayan of receiving a bribe of ₹3.28 crore through his daughter, based on the alleged admission of CMRL's former Chief Financial Officer Suresh Kumar.

Mr. Riyas, former Public Works Minister, was accused of "receipt of bribes



Pinarayi Vijayan

and transfer of such bribe funds to Dubai through Veena and known associates." Ms. Veena allegedly "assisted Mr. Vijayan and Mr. Riyas in collecting and routing bribe funds."

Exalogic Solutions Private Limited was allegedly used for "routing sham payments."

S.N. Sasidharan Kartha, Managing Director of CMRL, was accused of paying bribes, while CMRL's sister concern Empower India Capital Investments Private Limited was accused of transferring bribes.

Searches held

Last month, the ED said it had found "handwritten accounts maintained by Ms. Veena pertaining to ₹85 lakh allegedly transferred to Dubai." The notes contained "names of persons, amounts handled, spent" besides the amount transferred to Dubai.

The Kochi zonal office of the ED conducted search operations at nine premises in Kozhikode on August 18 under the PMLA in connection with the case.

Karnataka told to release 6,000 cusecs a day to T.N.

Cauvery Water Management Authority upholds CWRC order; Karnataka Minister calls decision illogical, says State is in the grip of drought and may approach SC; Tamil Nadu seeks more water

B.S. Satish Kumar
BENGALURU

The Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA), which met in Delhi on Tuesday, has upheld the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee's (CWRC) direction to Karnataka to ensure flows to the neighbouring Tamil Nadu at the rate of 6,000 cusecs a day for the next 15 days.

The CWRC issued this direction earlier in the day and Karnataka had challenged it before the CWMA. However, the CWMA endorsed the CWRC's decision and asked Karnataka to ensure a flow of 6,000 cusecs a day at Biligundlu inter-State water gauge for 15



Vital support: Farmers in Tiruchi welcome the release of Cauvery water from the Mettur reservoir for irrigation recently. M. MOORTHY

days, beginning 8 a.m. on September 9. The total quantum of water that has been ordered to be released amounts to approximately 7.8 tmc ft.

Karnataka Water Resources Minister N. Cheluv-arayaswamy expressed dis-

consulting Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar.

Expressing anguish over the order, he said, "The authorities who are issuing orders in Delhi are unable to understand the conditions on the ground."

Earlier, Karnataka told the CWMA that storage available in the four reservoirs of its Cauvery basin was critically inadequate and was barely enough to meet the State's needs.

Meanwhile, Tamil Nadu maintained that delayed releases would seriously affect Samba cultivation and the livelihood of farmers. It sought higher releases to the tune of 1.76 tmc ft a day (20,370 cusecs) for the next 15 days to clear its claimed backlog based on pro-rata entitlement.

Two BRS MLCs arrested for remarks against Assembly Speaker, released

R. Ravikanth Reddy
HYDERABAD

BRS MLCs Tata Madhu and Naveen Kumar Reddy, arrested by the Telangana Police on Tuesday, were suspended from the Legislative Council for the remainder of the session over alleged derogatory comments about Assembly Speaker Gaddam Prasad Kumar. They were released later after a trial court re-

jected the police plea for their remand.

Legislative Affairs Minister D. Sridhar Babu moved a resolution to suspend them and the House adopted it unanimously. The Chairman of the Legislative Council, Gutha Sukender Reddy, then announced their suspension.

Speaker Gaddam Prasad Kumar was not in the Chair when the motion was moved.

The resolution also said that Leader of the Opposition and BRS chief K. Chandrashekar Rao should take responsibility for the "unbecoming conduct" of his party members, and tender unconditional apology to the Speaker.

Protest and scuffle

Protesting against the suspension, other BRS MLCs raised slogans against Chief Minister A. Revanth

Reddy outside the House.

Meanwhile, tension prevailed near the farmhouse of Mr. Rao at Erravelli in Siddipet district as Congress workers and members of Dalit organisations tried to march towards the premises in protest against the remarks. Scuffles broke out between BRS workers and protesters at some checkpoints, while a few police personnel suffered minor injuries.

INBRIEF



Keralam CM, Sreedharan discuss high-speed rail

Technocrat E. Sreedharan met Keralam Chief Minister V. D. Satheesan in Thiruvananthapuram on Tuesday to discuss connectivity projects. The meeting focussed on the high-speed rail project connecting Thiruvananthapuram with Kannur, that had been proposed by Mr. Sreedharan, who earlier helmed the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation. In a social media post about the meeting, Mr. Satheesan said: "Held fruitful discussions on advancing key connectivity and development projects to ensure sustainable growth."

19 child labourers rescued from APMC yard in Bengaluru

As many as 19 children from different parts of the country working as child labourers at the Agricultural Produce Marketing Committee (APMC) yard at Yeshwanthpur in Bengaluru were rescued after Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar, who visited the area, was informed about the issue. Police said the rescued children comprised 13 from Bihar (12 boys and a girl), two each from West Bengal and Uttar Pradesh, and one boy each from Rajasthan and Karnataka. Further, 10 children found working on the roadside were rescued and produced before the Child Welfare Committee for further action. PTI

Two persons charred to death as truck plunges into gorge

A truck driver and cleaner died when their vehicle plunged into a gorge in Kadapa district of Andhra Pradesh on Tuesday and caught fire. The truck carrying cement bags nosedived into the gorge on the Guvvalacheruvu ghat road after its brakes reportedly failed while negotiating a steep curve. The driver Subramani and cleaner Palani died on the spot. Owing to dry vegetation in the area, the fire spread to nearby areas. Police personnel rushed to the spot with fire tenders and extinguished the fire.

HC stays trial in fireworks accident case

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Kerala High Court on Monday stayed the trial in the 2016 Puttingal Devi temple fireworks accident till September 14.

The High Court sought an explanation from the State regarding the change of public prosecutor in the proceedings before the trial court. The State was granted time to file a statement regarding the reasons for changing the prosecutor in the case and to produce records.

The accident in Kollam district had killed 109 people and injured 280 others. The blast damaged more than 300 houses.

Rising worry



Smoke billows from an industrial unit in Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh. The State Pollution Control Board has recently directed industries to take stringent measures to control emissions and ensure compliance with environmental norms. K.R. DEEPAK

Bharat Ratna awardee C.N.R. Rao gets notice over name mismatch in SIR form

Rishita Khanna
BENGALURU

Professor C.N.R. Rao, one of the country's most respected scientists who was born in Bengaluru, has now been asked to prove his identity, with the State election office issuing a notice to the 92-year-old over a spelling mismatch in his name.

The Office of the Chief Electoral Officer, Karnataka, is presently sending notices to over 43 lakh voters over discrepancies and other errors in enumeration forms that they submitted during the Special Intensive Revision. The list is now in the public domain.



Prof. C.N.R. Rao

Prof. Rao, a Bharat Ratna awardee, has been issued a notice over "self-name mismatch" – the older voter list records his name as Prof. C.N.R. Rao, while the current rolls carry it as "Proff. C.N.R.Rao, with an extra 'f'." "Self-mismatch" refers

to a logical discrepancy when an elector who is also present in the 2002 electoral roll uses details from the 2002 roll while filling out the SIR enumeration form, but the details in the 2002 roll and the current roll do not match.

Prof. Rao has been called for a hearing in Malleshwaram.

However, his acquaintances were not aware of the notice until *The Hindu* contacted them. They said Prof. Rao is not keeping well. His acquaintances at the Jawaharlal Nehru Centre for Advanced Scientific Research said he scarcely uses a phone and never checks his email himself.

Get going, don't wait for complaints, Naidu tells party leaders

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

TDP president and Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu on Tuesday asked party MLAs and public representatives to adopt best governance practices, stay connected with people and proactively resolve problems in their constituencies, "instead of waiting for complaints".

Addressing a leadership conclave on government and public services at the TDP office at Mangalagiri, he said that some constituencies were delivering better citizen services and urged all 175 Assembly constituencies to emulate it. Referring to the liquor



Strong condemnation: DMK legislators protesting before Speaker J.C.D. Prabhakar in the Assembly on Tuesday. ANI

DMK MLAs demand expunction of CM's remarks; stage sit-in

B. Kolappan
CHENNAI

DMK MLAs were evicted from the Assembly on the direction of Speaker J.C.D. Prabhakar on Tuesday after they staged a sit-in and raised slogans demanding the expunction of Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay's remarks on the Sarkaria Commission, the Maintenance of Internal Security Act (MISA), former Chief Minister M.K. Stalin, late DMK leader Murasoli Maran, and the dossier prepared by the Directorate of Enforcement (ED) against the previous DMK government.

Mr. Prabhakar made it clear that he would not expunge the remarks, saying the issues, particularly the Sarkaria Commission, had been debated in the House several times and the Chief Minister had quoted from an ED report that had already been in the public domain. "He has not said anything new," he said.

As the DMK MLAs insisted that the Chief Minister's

remarks be expunged, moved towards the Speaker's chair, and staged a sit-in, the Speaker said DMK whip E.V. Velu could express his views on the issue. Mr. Velu had raised the matter immediately after the proceedings began and demanded the expunction of the Chief Minister's remarks.

The DMK MLAs, however, remained firm on their demand. After trying to persuade them to return to their seats and Mr. Velu to speak, the Speaker ordered the Assembly's watch and ward staff to evict them. While most of the MLAs left the House, some were carried out. Valparai MLA Kutti, alias Sudhakar, resisted the eviction and created a ruckus.

Mr. Prabhakar said the Chief Minister had abided by the rules of the Assembly and spoken with adequate evidence. The Speaker said the dignity of the House should be protected and the people across the world were watching the proceedings.

'Pass order on plea for probe into site given to Kharge family trust'

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The High Court of Karnataka has faulted a special court for abandoning the course of ordering a Lokayukta police investigation into allegations of illegal allotment of a civic amenities site in Bengaluru to a trust of Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge's family and instead conducting an inquiry on its own under the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023, solely because of technical defects in the complainant's affidavit.

Justice M. Nagaprasanna passed the order while partly allowing a petition filed by Vijayaraghava Marathe, State president of Lanchamuktha Karnataka Vedike, Bengaluru. The petitioner had challenged the special court's August 11 order of taking up the inquiry by itself under Section 223 of BNSS instead of considering his plea for a probe by the Lokayukta police.

The special court had declined to proceed under Section 175(3) due to a "defective affidavit" filed by the complainant.

However, the High Court held that infirmity in the affidavit of the complainant is a "curable defect" while stating that the special court must afford the complainant an opportunity to cure defects before passing orders on merit.

The complaint alleges serious irregularities in the allotment of a civic amenity site in 2010 to the Sidarth Vihar Trust, a charitable trust of Mallikarjun Kharge and his family members.

Russia welcomes India's efforts to end Ukraine war

PAC flags failure to transfer ₹9,222 cr. in cess collections

SC presses Odisha to decide on Dara Singh plea for remission

VIT Chennai, *The Hindu* to hold conclave on the future of biotechnology on Sept. 11

Navy chief to visit Australia and New Zealand from today

Murmu gives Ladakh L-G additional charge of J&K

Centre steps away from row over Hindu group's visit to Eiffel Tower

Congress leaders in Punjab will work unitedly under Rahul, Kharge to defeat AAP, says Pilot

Tribal Affairs Ministry under pressure from 'Modani', says Congress on Gram Sabha issue

Rahul Gandhi arrives in Rae Bareli on two-day visit

Home Ministry to resume talks with Ladakh civil society groups

Citing inaction, Manipur Naga body plans to intensify highway blockade

CMYK

INBRIEF



5 young orangutans rescued from Odisha's Balasore district

The Odisha Forest Department on Tuesday rescued five young orangutans after they were found abandoned in a casuarina plantation in the Udayapur-Talsari forest area of Balasore district. The orangutans, which are not native to India, were found during routine patrolling, said Regional Chief Conservator of Forests Prakash Chand Gogineni. “We have rescued all of them. Of the five, three are male, and two are female,” Mr. Gogineni said. The orangutans, aged between six months and one year, have been shifted to Nandankanan Zoological Park for medical examination. Orangutans are naturally found in the forests of Indonesia and Malaysia. “It appears to be a botched-up transit operation,” he said.

Bombay HC refuses to quash summons against Rahul

The Bombay High Court on Tuesday refused to quash the summons issued to Rahul Gandhi, the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, in a defamation complaint over his remarks against Prime Minister Narendra Modi. A single Bench of Justice N.R. Borkar dismissed Mr. Gandhi's petition against the magistrate court's order. The High Court, however, continued its 2021 order directing the magistrate to defer hearing on the complaint for six weeks so that Mr. Gandhi can approach the Supreme Court in appeal. A BJP member had filed the complaint in the Girgaon court in Mumbai. The complaint was made over Mr. Gandhi's remarks during a rally in Jaipur, Rajasthan, on August 20, 2018.

Musician's death: Manipur CM, Rijiju seek swift action

Kharge, Rahul flag safety concerns of Northeast people; never imagined my son would become a victim of violence against people from Northeast in 'mainland', says mother of slain guitarist

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Union Minister Kiren Rijiju and Manipur Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh on Tuesday called for swift and strict action against those responsible for the killing of Manipuri music teacher Chongtham Vikram Singh. Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi condemned the killing and raised concerns over the safety of people from the Northeast in Delhi.

In Imphal, a candlelight vigil organised by the Thangmeiband United Club was held at the western gate of the Kangla Fort in memory of Chongtham Vikram. Participants sought justice for the slain guitarist and punishment for those involved. Chongtham Ongbi Kamala, Mr. Singh's 86-year-old mother and a reputed singer, said she never imagined her son would become a victim of violence against people from the Northeast in the “mainland”.

“I keep reading news about people from our region being assaulted or



People take part in a candlelight vigil condemning the killing of Manipur musician Chongtham Vikram Singh in New Delhi. PTI

killed in the metros and elsewhere in India. Today, the news is about my own son,” she said.

In a statement to the media, Mr. Rijiju said he had a detailed discussion with police officers, who informed him that all eight accused had been arrested.

He said the accused were food delivery workers belonging to different States, including Bihar, Jharkhand, Uttar Pradesh, and Madhya Pradesh. “The police have assured me that within eight to nine days a chargesheet will be filed and the strongest possible punishment will be given to these eight people,” he said, paying condolence

to the family of Mr. Singh. Mr. Rijiju said he was in constant touch with police officers, including those from the Special Police Unit for North-Eastern Region, for regular updates. The Manipur Chief Minister urged his Delhi counterpart Rekha Gupta to ensure a fair and time-bound probe. He said “the tragic incident is a painful reminder of the safety concerns faced by people from the Northeast who live, study and work in the national capital” and that “such incidents must not be treated as isolated cases”.

He also requested reinforced security measures across localities with significant populations of students and working professionals from Manipur and other northeastern States. Mr. Kharge said the “merciless lynching” by a mob was a “chilling reminder” of the alleged lawlessness under the BJP government. He said students, women, Dalits, Adivasis, and minorities remained vulnerable, while people from the Northeast continued to face discrimination.

“Under HM Amit Shah's watch, Delhi has become a crime capital, with the NCRB recording the highest levels of crime in the national capital year after year,” Mr. Kharge said in a post on X. He offered condolences to Mr. Singh's family and demanded “strictest action” against those responsible. He also accused the Centre of leaving people from Manipur to suffer both within and outside the State.

Mr. Gandhi, in a Facebook post, said the killing had raised questions about the safety of people from the Northeast living in Delhi. “After many such incidents, every Northeast family in Delhi is asking the same question today – are we safe here?” he said.

Fix accountability, says plea on police action case

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Days after the Supreme Court quashed the FIRs against the NEET-UG protesters, the primary petitioner in the case listed a string of reasons on Tuesday, alleging that the conduct of the Delhi police and the political executive was not only “contrary to constitutional guarantees but also manifestly criminal in character”.

In a rejoinder filed in the apex court to a mid-August police affidavit, advocate-petitioner Shailendra Mani Tripathi highlighted several factors surrounding the crackdown on July 20 against protesters, who were overwhelmingly students, including a “pre-emptive and militarised” deployment of paramilitary forces, the alleged de-

Petitioner alleged that the conduct of the Delhi Police was 'manifestly criminal in character'

liberate infiltration of “chaotic elements” into the peaceful procession like Swatantra Bhardwaj and others armed with sticks and clubs to engineer unrest, and the use of lathis, pellet guns, tear gas, and water cannons to “crush a peaceful demonstration against the government's flawed education policies”.

“Clear accountability must accordingly be fixed at the level of the senior-most officers who ordered or permitted the use of such force, as well as at the level of the political executive, namely the Union Mi-

nistry of Home Affairs, whose policy directives governed the deployment,” the rejoinder said.

Although the Supreme Court has constituted a High-Powered Enquiry Committee to examine allegations in connection with the July 20 violence, including police excess, the rejoinder argued that the larger question of whether the government could use prohibitory powers to “transform a constitutional right to protest to a privilege exercisable only with the permission of the authorities” still required an answer.

The right to peaceful assembly originated from the Constitution. The role of the police was to facilitate the peaceful exercise of constitutional rights while ensuring public order and safety, the rejoinder said.

U.P. judge awards 23rd death penalty in past five months

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

Stating that he would rather “die” than be labelled a “coward”, Muzaffarnagar additional district and sessions judge Ravi Kumar Diwakar, who has handed down 22 death sentences in past five months, on Monday awarded another death sentence in a dowry-murder case, taking the total to 23.

The judge had been in the spotlight earlier, notably after he allowed a survey of the Gyanvapi mosque premises in Varanasi in 2022.

In the latest death sentence, issued on September 7, the judge convicted Mohd. Nadeem of murdering his wife, Shahzadi, by pouring kerosene on her

Have complete trust in ISRO: French space agency

Hemanth C.S.
PARIS

The French space agency Centre National d'Etudes Spatiales (CNES) has said that it is not perturbed with the back-to-back failures of the Indian Space Research Organisation's (ISRO)'s workhorse rocket, the Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle (PSLV), and has complete trust in its Indian partner.

The PSLV is scheduled to launch the Indo-French TRISHNA (Thermal Infra-Red Imaging Satellite for High-resolution Natural Resource Assessment) mission next year. It is a collaborative endeavour between the ISRO and the CNES.

“There is always a risk with launches and we know the risks. You must trust your partners and



The ISRO is scheduled to launch the Indo-French TRISHNA mission on PSLV next year.

The PSLV had suffered two setbacks. On January 12, 2026, the PSLV-C62 mission carrying the EOS-N1 earth observation satellite failed to finish its intended trajectory after an anomaly was detected during the end of the third stage of the launch vehicle. On May 18, 2025, the PSLV-C61 mission had also failed due to an anomaly in the third stage of the rocket.

TRISHNA is engineered to deliver high spatial and high temporal resolution monitoring of earth's surface temperature, emissivity, and biophysical and radiation variables for surface energy budgeting at regional to global scale.

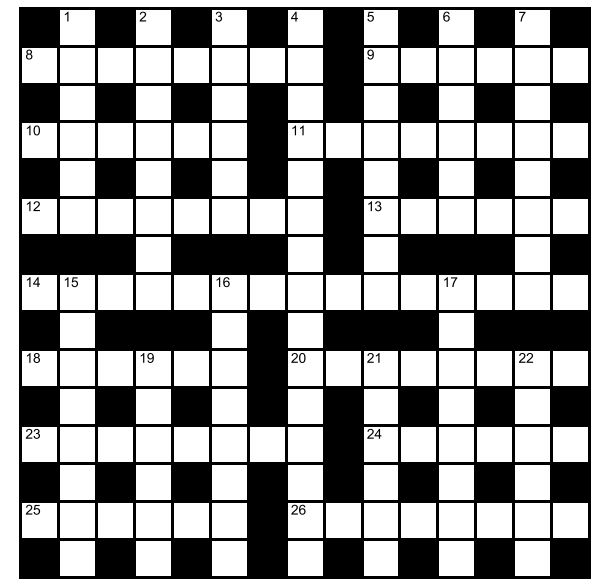
(The reporter is in Paris at the invitation of France's Ministry for Europe and Foreign Affairs to cover the International Space Summit)

THE CROSSWORD+ 14894

(set by Vidwan)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY



- 12

At home, heartless Spooner revels in the flesh (2-6)
- 13

Eskimo has time to sense! (6)
- 14

Adams must intuit going with due adjustments being made (7,8)
- 18

Life for English! It's oddly about public relations! (6)
- 20

Trick associated with common guilt (8)
- 23

One escaping from prison, most open to fly endlessly for a spicy curry (8)
- 24

Sesame seed paste in Thai cooking (6)
- 25

Lady's in hijab regularly for a medical condition (6)
- 26

English vote for instance sees different interpretations (8)
- Down
- 1

At heart, poor Phantom's an abandoned child! (6)
- 2

Oddly many bowed, without hint of courtesy before a gift by Patanjali (8)
- 3

He cures diseases and practices (6)
- 4

Saw changes in him around laundromat units (7,8)
- 5

Visionary one on US Narcs file (8)
- 6

Knight battled, sacrificed head for love (6)
- 7

It is a new transformed state (8)
- 15

Impassive United Nations has distorted judgement (8)
- 16

Thin disreputable women are back as God intended (2,3,3)
- 17

Half of this is in Scandinavian fringe of Atlantic (5,3)
- 19

Burden if error carries backward process (6)
- 21

Devotee with jewel from the east and a spice (6)
- 22

Kind of bicycle bars forged for bandmaster (6)

SUDOKU

3		4		1		5		
	8						3	
			9		3	4		
4			6				1	
7	2			8			9	5
	9				7			4
		1	2		6			
	7						6	
		2		9		1		3

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

Solution to previous puzzle

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

From moon’s far side, a satellite to look for the first radio signal

The 21-cm radio signal emitted by neutral hydrogen is like the proverbial needle in a haystack as it is buried beneath foreground radio emissions thousands of times stronger; to isolate it and reveal how the first stars and galaxies formed is a great challenge even for advanced platforms like the planned CosmoCube and India’s PRATUSH

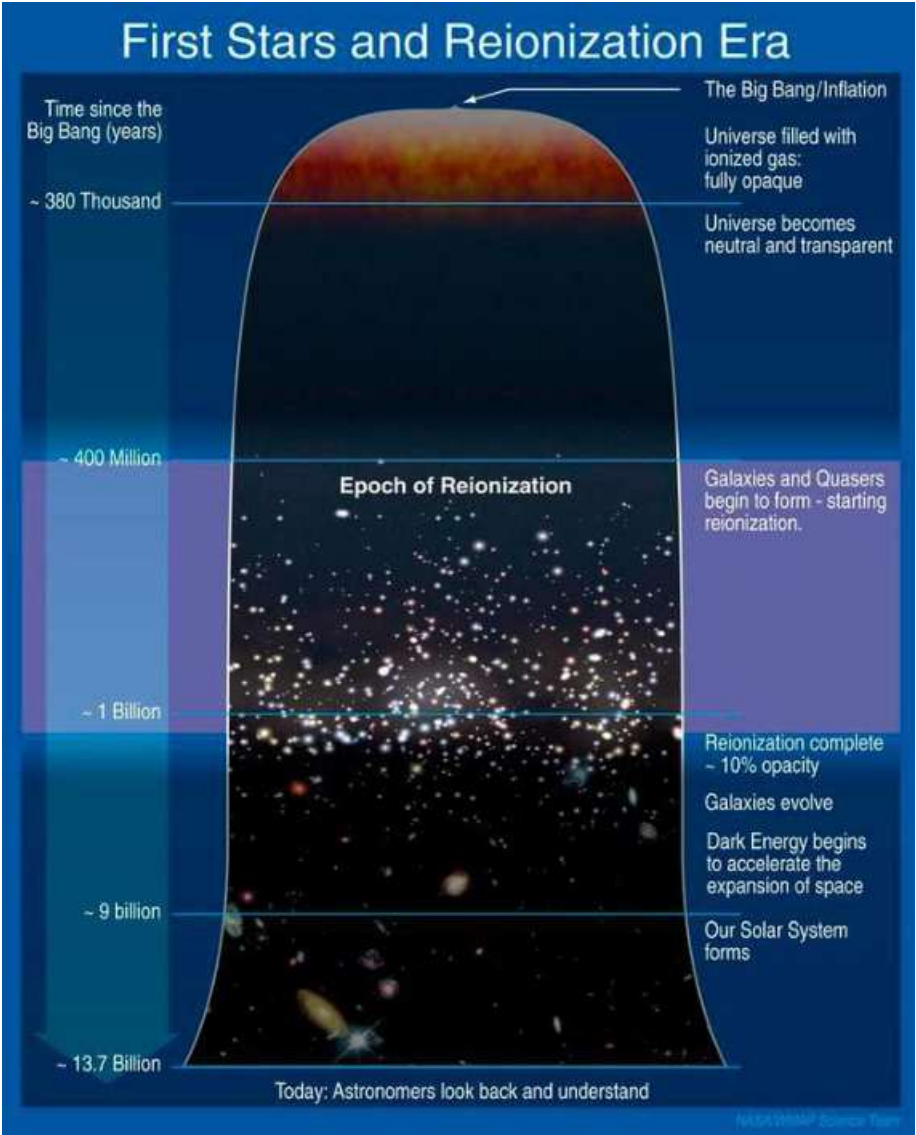
Prakash Chandra
KOCHI

Cosmologists are literally over the moon at the prospect of listening to the universe telling its story like never before. At the heart of this excitement is a small satellite named CosmoCube, which scientists from the Royal Astronomical Society (RAS) plan to send to the far side of the moon, which permanently faces away from the earth. Expected to be launched before the end of this decade, CosmoCube will orbit the moon and use it as a natural shield from radio interference generated on the earth.

Two-year mission
The compact satellite will have around 40 minutes on the lunar far side during its orbit every two hours, when it will be cut off from all radio noise from the earth. This is when it can capture ultra-faint cosmic signals, particularly one emitted by neutral hydrogen atoms – the most abundant element in space. “While passing behind the moon, the satellite would listen for an extremely faint radio ‘whisper’ produced by hydrogen in the very young universe, before the first stars and galaxies had fully formed,” Eloy de Lera Acedo, head of the Radio Astronomy and Cosmology research group at the University of Cambridge, who is leading the project, said via email. A study on the CosmoCube project was published in *Nature Astronomy* on August 14.

The RAS researchers expect the satellite to gather more than a thousand hours of data during its two-year mission. “During its scientific observations, CosmoCube would ideally remain radio-silent while behind the moon, so that its own communications did not contaminate the measurement. The recorded data could then be transmitted to the earth during a different part of its orbit,” Dr. de Lera Acedo said. “The satellite carries a very sensitive and accurately calibrated radio receiver, or radiometer, operating at low frequencies (10-100 MHz) which would separate the incoming radio waves into many frequency channels so that scientists [can] search for the characteristic fingerprint of early hydrogen.”

Dark ages
Current models of the universe suggest that once upon a spacetime, right after being engendered by the Big Bang, the



Cosmic dawn: A timeline of the early universe, from the Big Bang to the present. NASA

universe must have been a very dark place filled with neutral hydrogen. This inky black period is called the Cosmic Dark Ages. It stretched from about 3,80,000 years to around 200 million years after the Big Bang. The first stars and galaxies were yet to ignite their nuclear furnaces and switch on the lights in the universe, ushering in what is known as the Cosmic Dawn. Today, we can detect blurred pictures of that infant universe in the cosmic microwave background (CMB), the primaeval radiation emitted shortly after the Big Bang. But no one quite understands what happened during the subsequent Dark Ages as there is nothing for even the state-of-the-art instruments of today to ‘see’ of that mysterious era. In that sense, the story of the universe would have been left untold at that point but for a Dutch astronomer, Hendrik van de Hulst. In 1944, Van de Hulst predicted

a rare quantum mechanical phenomenon called a spin-flip transition that could have prompted the neutral hydrogen filling the cosmos to emit a feeble light. He reckoned that this light could be detected at a specific wavelength of 21 cm. Unlike visible light, this ancient radiation, whose corresponding frequency is 1,420 MHz, penetrates interstellar dust clouds to bring us snapshots from the very beginning of space and time. (Of course, as the universe expands, this radiation is stretched to wavelengths of many metres by the time it reaches us.)

First lights
In 1951, the U.S. physicists Harold Ewen and Edward Purcell at Harvard University observed the 21-cm radiation for the first time, heralding the age of spectral-line astronomy.

It meant cosmologists could pick up the story of the universe again because they had a means to study the Dark Ages, one of the few periods in cosmic history that has never been directly observed. Around 150 million to one billion years after the Big Bang, light from the first stars and galaxies split the ubiquitous neutral hydrogen in the cosmos into free electrons and protons. This ‘Era of Reionisation’ lifted the dark cosmic fog from the universe and made it transparent, traces of which we now see as the cosmic microwave background. CosmoCube will also help investigate the Hubble tension: the difference in results when we measure the expansion of the universe by studying nearby celestial systems and the CMB of the early universe. “CosmoCube would not simply make another direct measurement of today’s Hubble constant,” Dr. de Lera Acedo said. “Instead, it would examine a largely unexplored period between the CMB and the formation of the first stars.” This will help cosmologists test some of the new-physics explanations proposed for the Hubble tension, including dark matter (which does not emit or reflect light but accounts for more than 80% of the universe’s mass).

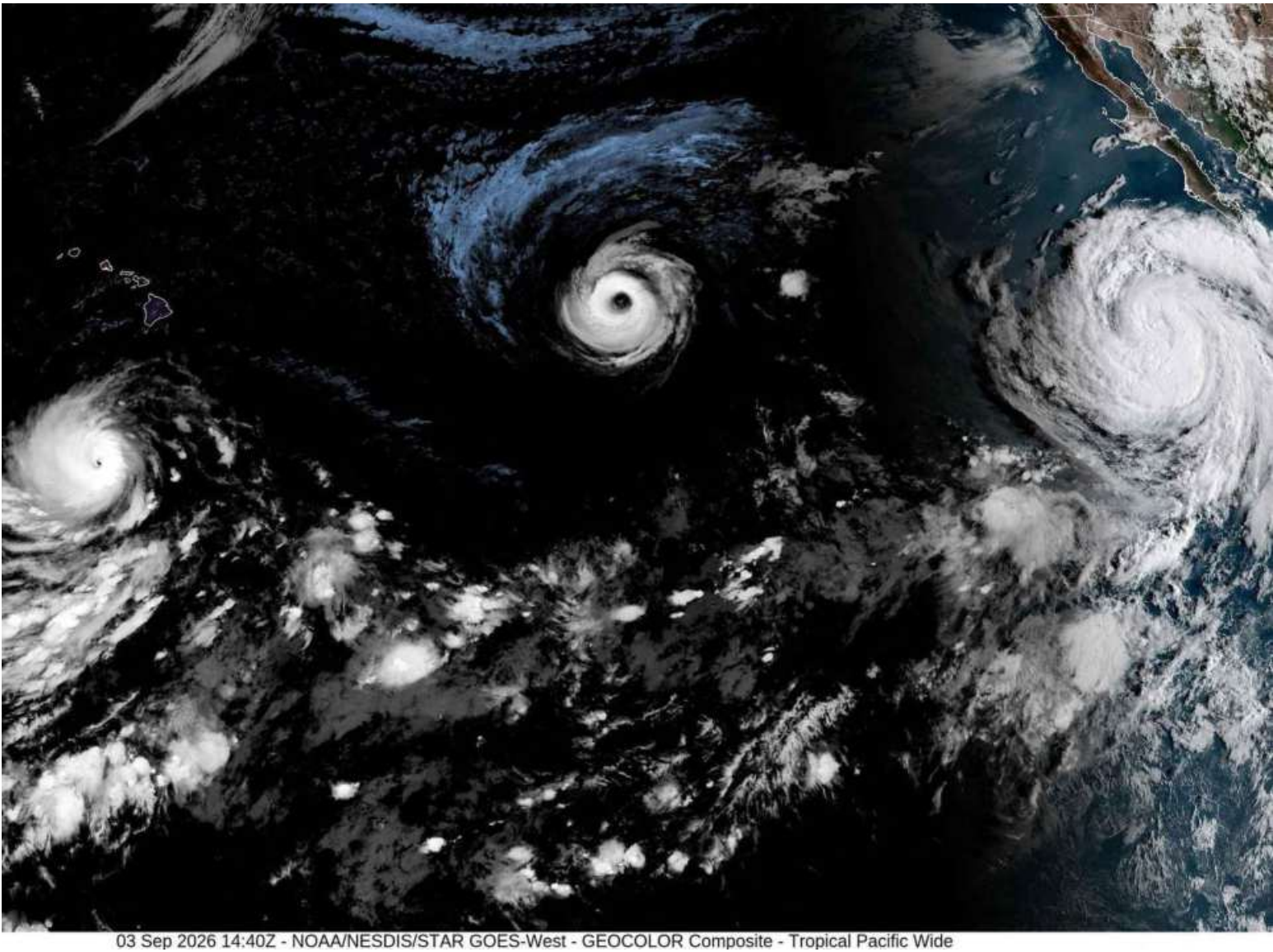
‘Extraordinary promise’
As Dr. de Lera Acedo put it, “If a model changes the early expansion history, introduces an additional radio background, or allows new interactions between dark matter and ordinary matter, it may leave a measurable signature in the 21-centimetre signal. CosmoCube could provide an independent test of such ideas.” The 21-cm signal from neutral hydrogen is like the proverbial needle in a haystack as it is buried beneath foreground radio emissions probably tens of thousands of times stronger. To isolate it and reveal how the very first stars and galaxies formed is a formidable challenge even for advanced platforms such as CosmoCube and India’s PRATUSH – a proposed radio telescope and radiometer in lunar orbit (its name is short for ‘Probing ReionisAtion of the Universe using Signal from Hydrogen’). As Dr. de Lera Acedo said, “That combination, extraordinary scientific promise coupled with extraordinary experimental difficulty, is precisely why the radio-quiet environment behind the moon is so valuable.”

(Prakash Chandra is a science writer. prakashisat@gmail.com)

THE GIST

- Expected to be launched before the end of this decade, CosmoCube will orbit the moon and use it as a natural shield from radio interference generated on the earth
- The compact satellite will have around 40 minutes on the lunar far side during its orbit every two hours, when it will be cut off from all radio noise from the earth
- CosmoCube will also help investigate the Hubble tension: the difference in results when we measure the expansion of the universe by studying nearby celestial systems and the cosmic microwave background of the early universe

BIG SHOT



03 Sep 2026 14:40Z - NOAA/NESDIS/STAR GOES-West - GEOCOLOR Composite - Tropical Pacific Wide

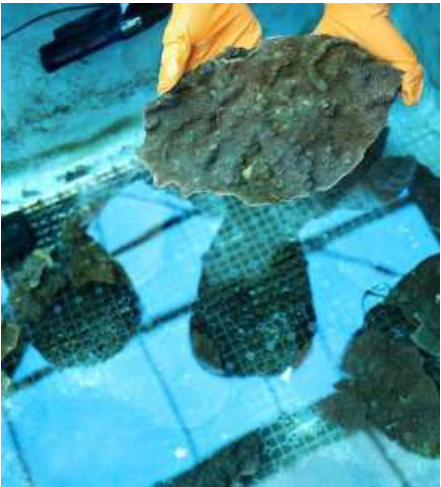
Triple threat: This satellite image from the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration shows Hurricanes Lowell (L), Karina (C), and Marie (R) over the Pacific Ocean on September 3. Scientists have attributed this rare trio of hurricanes to waters warmed by a historically strong El Nino. AFP

WHAT IS IT?

Slumping: a soft-coral threat

Reuters

Ko Myeong-hyo loved the vibrant colour and thriving life of South Korea’s soft corals when she first began diving off the coast of Jeju island six years ago, looking to harvest seafood for sale. “Watching the coral garden collapse and turn white, it was so disorienting,” Ko says now, after two years of rising temperatures and harsher weather brought by climate change have led to many corals slumping over and dying. “I was afraid the whole sea might be collapsing.” The ‘slumping’ phenomenon is showing up again this year, says the Paran Ocean Citizen Science Centre, a group of divers who monitor the island’s UNESCO-listed soft corals, mostly around uninhabited islets south of Jeju. Unlike hard corals supported by rigid calcium carbonate skeletons, soft corals rely on internal fluid pressure to keep upright. Environmental changes can disrupt that pressure, leading them to slump or collapse. “If another large-scale ‘slumping’ happens, corals partially recover and then a lot break off and deteriorate again, and that keeps repeating, their capacity to recover just keeps declining,” said researcher Kim Taihun. Kim and Anna Beate Jöst, a colleague at the Korea Institute of Ocean Science and Technology, documented Jeju’s 2024 soft coral slumping event for the first time in a May article in the journal *Scientific Reports*.



Reef research: A scientist checks corals with researchers at a lab called Jeju TROPICA, in Jeju, South Korea on August 20, 2026. REUTERS

Kim said this year’s event resembled that of 2024, but could worsen should high water temperatures persist through September, and the historic El Nino may trigger typhoons and heavy rains. Coral researchers say such weather conditions, plus water flowing down from China’s Yangtze River affecting the area’s salinity, can trigger slumping.

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to letters@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Science’



Falling edifice

Delhi's ambition as an education hub is at odds with its civic infrastructure

The collapse of a five-storey building in Delhi, being run as a private hostel that killed seven and injured five in a densely populated colony abutting Delhi University's South Campus, has brought to light the twin issues of haphazard development in the capital city's residential areas and the shortage of affordable housing for students. With over 70,000 students entering Delhi University every year and almost half of them needing accommodation on a student budget, the city has failed to keep up with the growing demand. The University has, for all practical purposes, absolved itself of the responsibility, citing lack of land, leaving private players to cash in and run paying guest accommodations or private hostels that are not regulated. In a setup where every extra bed means more revenue, matchbox-sized rooms, often located in buildings that flout building bylaws and fire safety regulations and have no ventilation, are what several students call home. As soon as they arrive in the capital, students from many parts of the country realise that they are paying to live in the city not just in monetary terms but with their safety, security and sanity.

The Delhi government says that it wants the city to be a national education hub and harness the soft power of its youth, but that will be not possible without addressing the need for affordable, safe student housing. The Delhi government has suspended five senior officers of the civic body, ordered a probe and announced that it was working on introducing a stringent policy under which every building used for public activity would be required to undergo periodic structural audits and obtain safety certifications. It must go beyond these reactive measures to seek more durable solutions. In 2024, the basement of a coaching centre flooded due to heavy rains claiming the lives of three civil service aspirants. After that incident as well, probes were ordered, basements were sealed and legal action was taken against owners but a larger systemic change remains elusive. The Centre and the Government of NCT must work together with educational institutions to develop more residential, travel and learning facilities for students. The introduction of four-year undergraduate programmes also means that students will stay on for an additional year, increasing the pressure on accommodation. Private hostels can be part of the solution, but crumbling civic infrastructure, illegal construction and lack of safety audits must be tackled through policy and strict enforcement.

Perilous retreat

Gram sabhas must have a veto on issues relating to tribal land

Tribal organisations should recognise the Indian state's attempt to lower the legal barriers erected by the Forest Rights Act (FRA) as a threat to their survival. The Committee on Public Undertakings' suggestion that a project require the consent of only most, rather than all, gram sabhas affected by that project, as the FRA intends in spirit, portends a significant jurisprudential change. A regime that deems the acquiescence of 70%-75% of affected gram sabhas to suffice will reduce gram sabhas from democratic bodies protecting the constitutional rights of its specific inhabitants to corporate stakeholders. If the rule enters force, a project developer may bypass the consent of a village located directly within a proposed reservoir, say, while ensuring that less affected villages have provided their no-objection certificates. The matter is of a piece with the political fight over classifying tribal communities: by altering the demographic composition of who qualifies as a community member, the state will have an easier time splitting a village assembly and engineering consent. The refusal of the Tribal Affairs Ministry to claim jurisdiction over this issue creates a dangerous regulatory vacuum that leaves the Centre and State governments unchecked to rewrite the rules by which forested land is diverted for non-forest use. While the FRA does not include a clause requiring a no-objection certificate from every affected gram sabha, it is untrue that there is at present no legal requirement that gram sabha decisions can be bypassed.

The government has been rapidly scaling up energy infrastructure, including the long-stalled Teesta-IV project, to meet macroeconomic goals while, in a previous avatar, having passed the FRA to undo "historical injustices" meted out to forest-dependent communities. But the path the state seems willing to pursue, hewing to the notion that the consent requirement was never part of the FRA, is plainly ignoble. If the Environment Ministry entertains the idea, it must change the relevant rules or legislation openly and democratically. The Tribal Affairs Ministry resorting to a technicality, between the FRA and the Environment Ministry's rules, to recuse itself is hardly better as the bureaucratic manoeuvre could strip forest-dependent communities of their most potent legal instrument. The foundation of these communities' livelihoods, culture, identity, and political autonomy is land, so they have fought to resist displacement and dispossession and to secure customary collective ownership. In recognition of the social and environment services ST communities continue to render in India and their contribution to national development, including helping meet India's climate commitments, the Centre and States must also strengthen the powers conferred by the Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement and Panchayats (Extension to Scheduled Areas) Acts to gram sabhas in Scheduled Areas.

Indian students, particularly Gen Z, are increasingly asserting their freedom and autonomy and demanding accountability. Now, some of the brightest law students are in the news for the wrong reasons, but Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant deserves some credit for his timely intervention in staying the Bar Council of India (BCI)'s atrocious order about the NALSAR graduating batch; quashing all FIRs against the protesting students; declaring that the BCI has no disciplinary control over the students, and reducing the three-year practice condition to just one year to write the judicial services examination.

The question is not whether the students were right or wrong in seeking a say in their own convocation. The real question is why students are so upset with the governance model of universities that, at times, they not only lose hope but also cross the boundaries of decency and satire. To suggest that this happened simply because of an oral remark by the CJI, which was quickly clarified, is to oversimplify the deeper governance crisis in higher education. How should universities be governed? What is the role of free speech and academic autonomy? And why are Vice-Chancellors increasingly unable to command students' respect or resolve such issues internally?

At the core must lie academic freedom

Universities cannot function without academic freedom. The Indian Constitution does not explicitly mention academic freedom but there are number of Constitutions which do have such a provision such as Article 5(3) of German Basic Law specifically guarantees right to scientific freedom (Wissenschaftsfreiheit) as the constitutional right to everyone engaged in scholarly teaching and research. The Constitutions of Japan, South Africa, Portugal and Spain too contain such a freedom. Article 137 of Basic Law of Hong Kong says that educational institutions may retain autonomy and enjoy academic freedom. Ideally, government should not dictate universities what to teach, how to teach and what not to teach. Nor should universities deny this freedom to departments and faculties. Recently, the Delhi University dropped a paper on Delhi Sultanate along with some other papers. Gen Z is intelligent enough to see that such curriculum changes have ideological reasons. University curriculum should ideally be decided by the stakeholders including students.

Academic freedom and free speech on university campuses are extremely important as universities are supposed to provide a special place for reflection, inquiry and discussion. It is nobody's case that they have any right to defame people or indulge in anti-national activities. If an academic activity involves 'conduct' rather than free speech, the state would certainly be entitled



Faizan Mustafa

Vice-Chancellor of Chanakya National Law University, Patna, having previously served as Vice-Chancellor of NALSAR, Hyderabad, and the National Law University Odisha (NLUO), Cuttack

Blame the failures of university governance, not students, for growing protests across Indian campuses

to regulate such 'conduct'. Today, even in the West, academic freedom is under serious strain. Federal funding in the U.S. has been weaponised to reshape campus culture, diversity programmes have been dismantled, and research funding in areas such as climate change has been reduced. Universities have also faced pressure for allowing student protests, including those over Gaza. Both right- and left-wing regimes have, at times, sought to control universities.

History offers many examples – from Arnold Toynbee's resignation from King's College London in 1924 over his writings on the Greek army's atrocities, to the persecution of professors during the McCarthy era. With declining public funding, research agendas are increasingly influenced by funders, corporations, and pharmaceutical companies, making a mockery of academic freedom.

The shadow of 'control'

We are witnessing student protests because universities are not governed well. Governments increasingly seek to control universities, and administrations have consequently adopted a 'control model' of governance. Most universities remain Vice-Chancellor-centric, while students – who are the very reason universities exist – have little say in their governance. When grievances are not addressed promptly, students feel ignored and suffocated; some take extreme steps. The government is often blamed, but much of the backlash could be avoided if university administrations engaged students in meaningful dialogue and provided timely relief. Vice-Chancellors rarely hold open houses and are often inaccessible to ordinary students. Universities are communities of highly educated faculty and intelligent young people; they require dialogue, trust and openness – not excessive control and surveillance.

The object of universities is to innovate and create knowledge, but knowledge creation cannot happen in a controlled environment. It requires the freedom to question everything and challenge existing ideas. Despite the repeated reverence for ancient India, India's education system remains over-regulated and grossly underfunded. Its ancient Gurukul system was entirely autonomous, yet, today, India remains far from the National Education Policy 2020's promise of public investment of 6% of GDP in education. Public investment in education has steadily declined, hovering around 4%-4.1%, with higher education investment getting the smallest pie.

Meanwhile, public university infrastructure has deteriorated and there is an acute shortage of hostels leading to tragedies such as the one in New Delhi, faculty positions remain vacant, and guest faculty are poorly paid. Faculty recruitment processes are faulty with an over-emphasis on ideological leanings rather than merit. Poor teaching frustrates students, while repeated

examination paper leaks add to their stress. Eventually, this frustration erupts – not against university administrations, but against the government itself.

We even over-look gross violations of natural justice principles in the appointment of Vice-Chancellors. In one case, a Vice-Chancellor not only changed the composition of the selection committee but also chaired it and voted in the selection of his wife. She was appointed as Vice-Chancellor, and the judiciary declined to follow its own precedents of quashing such appointments. Ultimately, the government received the brickbats for the actions of the Vice-Chancellor.

On the 'liberty model'

Over 16 years as a Vice-Chancellor, this writer implemented what can be described as the new 'liberty model of governance' across three universities. Such a model works when students are trusted and, they in turn, act more responsibly. Students have often felt comfortable in meeting the Vice-Chancellor without appointments, sometimes sharing personal concerns and difficulties. This trust has also made it easier to have frank conversations with them, including when difficult or unpopular decisions had to be taken.

Unlike the 'control' or top-down model, the 'liberty model' views universities as spaces where even the most unpopular ideas can be freely debated. Students should have a meaningful role in academic, administrative and financial decisions, including faculty appointments, procurement, curriculum design and drafting of university regulations. In older institutions such as Aligarh Muslim University, students even have a statutory role in selecting the Vice-Chancellor. We need to democratise our campuses if we want to address the growing problem of student protests.

Ideological governments may in a few cases prefer candidates who have particular ideological leanings, but merit should not be completely undermined. There have also been appointments of individuals with questionable records and adverse CVC reports, while some State universities face allegations of bribery. Paper leaks reflect a similar systemic failure. No examination system can be foolproof if paper setters, moderators or testing officials are appointed for reasons other than absolute merit and integrity.

If the government really wants to win back the confidence of students, universities must become student-centric rather than Vice-Chancellor-centric. Let us embrace the liberty model and reject the dated and regressive control model of university governance. India's students deserve nothing less than the best.

The views expressed are personal

India-Japan defence cooperation breaks new ground

The August 2026 visit of Japan's Defence Minister Shinjiro Koizumi to India marks an important moment in the evolution of a partnership that has often been more developed institutionally than operationally. The agreements that were announced suggest that New Delhi and Tokyo are now attempting to connect these disparate strands into a more coherent security relationship, having spent more than a decade building the institutional vocabulary of defence cooperation through annual dialogues, the 2+2 mechanism, exercises, logistics arrangements and defence technology discussions.

Convergence into operational capability

This matters because the India-Japan defence relationship has reached a stage where additional declarations of strategic convergence have diminishing returns. Both countries already share concerns about coercive attempts to alter the status quo, the security of maritime commons and the growing militarisation of the Indo-Pacific. The challenge has been translating these convergences into arrangements that improve their ability to operate together. The new maritime framework seeks to address this issue.

The emphasis on information sharing and Maritime Domain Awareness is significant as India and Japan occupy critical positions at opposite ends of the Indo-Pacific's principal maritime theatre. Japan's immediate security concerns are concentrated in the East China Sea and the waters surrounding Taiwan, while India's geographical position gives it a central role in the Indian Ocean maritime space. A closer information-sharing architecture could gradually create a more continuous strategic picture across these interconnected maritime spaces. The objective is to develop greater awareness, interoperability, and operational familiarity between the two major maritime powers.

The discussions on naval shipbuilding may prove equally important with an exploration of joint development in naval shipbuilding and



Harsh V. Pant

Vice-President at the Observer Research Foundation



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India and Japan are advancing a broader Indo-Pacific partnership beyond China-centric security concerns

design by combining Japanese technological expertise with Indian production capabilities. There was also agreement to deepen discussions on Japan's use of Indian production capabilities under the 'Make in India' framework and to move towards reciprocal arrangements for ship repair facilities. This could address a long-standing weakness in the bilateral relationship by giving a fillip to defence-industrial cooperation, which has consistently lagged behind strategic and political convergence.

The proposed transfer of Japan's UNICORN integrated communications antenna system remains the most visible symbol of this effort. While the Japanese Ministry of Defence describes UNICORN as the first defence equipment transfer project between the two countries, the project itself is not new. A memorandum of understanding for the co-development of UNICORN masts, involving Bharat Electronics Limited, was signed in November 2024. The August meeting therefore represented a further step towards implementation rather than the initiation of a new project. New Delhi and Tokyo have struggled to convert their 2015 agreement on defence equipment and technology transfer into concrete outcomes. The commitment now to early implementation, alongside plans to deepen cooperation between India's Defence Research and Development Organisation and Japan's Acquisition, Technology and Logistics Agency, suggests a recognition that credibility today depends on delivering projects rather than solely identifying possibilities.

On exercises

Japan's fighter aircraft are participating in the Veer Guardian exercise in India (September 9-22, 2026) for the first time. The two sides have agreed to increase the complexity of bilateral exercises, integrate unmanned systems and explore exercises organised at short notice. They also discussed cooperation between special operations forces and India's future integrated theatre commands. These initiatives point

towards a defence relationship increasingly concerned with operational preparedness.

Before travelling to New Delhi, Mr. Koizumi visited the Western Naval Command in Mumbai and INS Chennai. His visit thus extended beyond the familiar strategic geography of the Bay of Bengal and the Strait of Malacca. The western seaboard is central to India's wider maritime interests, encompassing critical sea lanes, energy flows and India's growing responsibilities in the western Indian Ocean.

The broader regional context is impossible to ignore. The joint statement reiterated opposition to unilateral actions that impede freedom of navigation or seek to alter the status quo through force or coercion. Neither country needed to name China for the strategic message to be clear. Yet, the significance of India-Japan cooperation lies precisely in its ability to move beyond a China-centric agenda. Maritime security, resilient supply chains, defence industrial capacity, logistics and third-country cooperation are all becoming components of a wider regional security architecture.

Building a more resilient partnership

The visit also plugs into a broader moment of impetus in India-Japan relations. Coming soon after the July 2026 Annual Summit, which expanded cooperation across economic security, critical technologies and resilient supply chains, the defence ministerial engagement demonstrates that security is increasingly intertwined with the wider strategic partnership. Defence cooperation can provide the connective tissue between these agendas, linking India's industrial capabilities and Japan's technological strengths while reinforcing their shared interest in shaping a more resilient Indo-Pacific. The real test will now be implementation. India and Japan are building the strategic foundations, with Mr. Koizumi's visit suggesting that both are finally beginning to focus on the harder task, which is converting strategic convergence into usable capability.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Building safety

There must be many reasons for the building collapse in Delhi. Construction of the majority of the small buildings is done without the consultation of civil engineers who know, among others, the

intricacies of the load bearing capacity of the walls, quality of concrete and steel rods and the requirements of foundation integrity which are critical aspects. The owners of the building go by the advice of the masons. The undesirability of this

practice gets amplified when buildings are multi-storied or additional floors are added; so are buildings with basements which may be vulnerable during the rainy season. In the instant case, it is shocking to read that the building collapsed when

repairs were carried out in the basement. In the recent past, Delhi experienced heavy unseasonal rains which may be one reason that had probably added to the fragility of the building. (Front page, September 8).
V. Lakshmanan,
Tirupur, Tamil Nadu

Revised map

The move to promote equal-area map projections will ensure cartographic fairness. However, handling politically contested regions requires strict diplomatic neutrality. Depicting contested zones with neutral line indicators and

explanatory notes will ensure that global mapping efforts do not become a catalyst for further geopolitical tensions.
Harrell Roji,
Bengaluru

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Beyond a monolithic Gen Z youth

The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protests were a momentous breakthrough in Indian politics. Through them, the appellation “Gen Z” has entered the everyday lexicon. Yet most of the sympathetic commentary on the movement has placed the Gen Z youth in a mythical, monolithic space. Instead of homogenising an entire generation, cautious empirical assessments are the need of the hour. After all, Gen Z youth are a staggering 400 million in India alone.

While this generation is now seen as a vehicle of anti-ruling party/ establishment sentiments, in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) received 39% and 37% of the votes from those aged 18 to 25 years and 26-35 years respectively (CSDS-Lokniti post-poll survey). Crucially, these were more than the 35% votes obtained from those aged 56 and above. Similarly, the National Democratic Alliance had a 46% vote share among 18-25 year-olds, but only 41% among those aged above 56.

Thus, rather than seeing Gen Z youth as only a uniform entity, it is important to understand the divisions within, and, also, the commonalities with other generations. After all, the central actors of the anti-CAA (Citizenship (Amendment) Act) and farmer protests were the older generations.

Fractures within

Even as the Gen Z youth have played a critical role in social justice movements globally, such as Black Lives Matter, survey data and studies suggest important



Nissim Mannathukkaren

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fractures within the generation, especially regarding gender, class, race, and political ideology.

A *Financial Times* report shows that American and German women (aged 18-30) are 30 percentage points more liberal than their male counterparts, while it is 25% in the U.K. Similar serious gender rifts have developed in South Korea, China, Tunisia, etc., triggered by movements such as #MeToo. The advancing feminist movement has led to young men feeling embattled, leading to nearly half of the American male youth complaining of reverse discrimination.

In a scholarly study of 32 European countries, it was found that there was no gender gap in political ideology amongst young people in 14 nations; a stable gender gap in 7; and in the remaining 11 nations, there was a widening, where women were either moving left and men, right, or women were moving to the left faster than men.

Attitudes towards democracy also differ within Gen Z. In the U.S., only half of the eligible Gen Z voters voted in the 2024 presidential elections: the lowest turnout amongst age groups. Contrary to popular notions, the youth vote shifted substantially to U.S. President Donald Trump.

There are still significant ideological divergences within Gen Z. While 43% of Gen Z Republicans say that African Americans face discrimination compared to only 20% of Gen X (1965-1980), Boomer (1946-1964), and Silent Generation (1928-1945) Republicans, it is 82% amongst Gen Z Democrats, and that number is only marginally less for older

generation Democrats (Pew Research 2018).

Moreover, even as the commentariat euphoria has focused on the uniqueness of Gen Z, there are areas where Gen Z attitudes have matched other generations. In the U.S., this is especially true regarding the millennial generation (1981-1996) who align with Gen Z on many issues. Social media usage and polarisation percentage amongst Gen Z was like those of other generations (Stanford University student survey), and there was almost near conformity across generations about the positives of more women in politics.

There is also a remarkable split developing within the Gen Z youth; there are now divergences between Gen Z 1.0 (Ages 23-29) and Gen Z 2.0 (Ages 13-22). A Yale University youth poll showed that ages 22-29 preferred Democratic candidates while ages 18-21 preferred Republican candidates in the 2026 congressional elections.

While these global characteristics do not exactly map onto India's reality, in India, too, not only questions of gender, but attitudes of ‘upper caste’ Gen Z on caste equality and reservation, and Hindu Gen Z on religious majoritarianism would be critical.

George Orwell had once written that “Each generation imagines itself to be more intelligent than the one that went before it, and wiser than the one that comes after it,” which he termed as an illusion. To avoid such illusions, we need more fine-grained studies on Indian Gen Z to understand its composition in all its social complexity.

Women should take back the night

The Leader of the Opposition, Rahul Gandhi, recently caught patriarchy by the horns at Pune's ‘Chhatron Ki Goonj’ women-only conclave.

He confronted the vulnerability of women in public spaces by explicitly framing women's autonomy as ownership not only of their bodies but of their lives. Instead of considering women merely as a constituency to be protected, Rahul Gandhi questioned the very “cage” in which women are confined on the pretext of safety. This intervention echoes a seminal argument on women's mobility by Rebecca Solnit in her book *Wanderlust: A History of Walking*, where she explores how the freedom to walk alone at night and to discover the world on one's own terms has historically been a male prerogative – a right denied to women.

Feminist theorist Catharine MacKinnon argued that male dominance exercises its force as consent and its control as the definition of legitimacy. Patriarchal control operates through practices presented as protection and cultural legitimacy. When Indian women contest these restrictions, cultural narratives and religious scriptures are weaponised to preserve the status quo. This systemic oppression is then presented as “Indian culture.” However, in *Culture and Society*, Raymond Williams reminds us that culture is never a singular, homogenised, fixed, or unalterable monolith. Rather, it is a dynamic reaction to the changing “conditions of our common life.” Williams



Ragini Nayak

National Spokesperson, INC and former President, DUSU

argues that while the idea of culture describes our common inquiry, “our conclusions are as diverse as our starting points.” The understanding of culture as an unalterable value system fails to see Indian culture as a composite entity shaped by caste, class, religion, region, and ways of life. For example, the practice of ‘Sati Pratha’, once construed as central to Indian culture, is today deemed one of the most savage and inhuman rituals.

Challenging status quo

Rahul Gandhi challenged the interpretation of Indian culture as an unchanging entity by publicly condemning the Manusmriti's dictates on women. He struck at the literal text of ancient paternalism: “*Pita rakshati kaumaare, bharta rakshati yauvane, rakshanti sthavire putra; na stri swaatantryamarhati*” (a woman is protected by her father in childhood, by her husband in youth, and by her son in old age; a woman does not deserve independence). In doing so, he also drew a sharp ideological battle line against the foundational philosophy of Hindutva. It is worth remembering that M.S. Golwalkar revered Manu as the “first and greatest lawgiver of the world” and advocated for the Manusmriti to serve as the constitution of independent India.

The argument that reducing a woman's identity to just three boxes – daughter, wife, or mother – denies her the right to belong to herself seamlessly connected the everyday anxieties of young Indian women to this deep, historical architecture of male custody. No longer is the question simply whether women are safe; it is whether women are free. The call to

“break the cage” was therefore not the usual, toothless metaphor for empowerment. It was a direct assault on the idea of male guardianship.

Historically, the night has belonged to men. Girls, from a very tender age, are made to fear the night; of venturing out alone in darkness. Consequently, a woman's mental energy is consumed by the constant, exhausting labour of safeguarding her body. Simple mobility becomes a calculated risk, forcing women to monitor their posture, clothing, timing, and surroundings just to exist safely in public spaces.

While a structural shift is underway in urban India, it is driven by economic necessity rather than societal liberation. The growth of a 24/7 service economy – spanning IT, aviation, healthcare, and journalism – has propelled Indian women into night shifts. Yet infrastructure remains stubbornly hostile. Dark stretches, unlit transit hubs, a lack of clean public restrooms, and perilous last-mile connectivity ensure that night travel remains hazardous. Economic utility, therefore, must not be confused with emancipation. True spatial reclamation requires moving from forced utility to unconditional freedom, where a woman can occupy the night without fear.

In the 1970s, European and American women took to the streets at night under the banner ‘Take Back the Night.’ For Indian women to fully reclaim the night, the practices that negatively impact women's enjoyment of basic human rights must be done away with. Women must break the cage, take back the night, and wander.

Government could have foreseen the spike in sugar prices

While the government attributed a range of factors for the sharp increase, analysis showed that there were ample signals warning of a potential surge

DATA POINT

Gauri Singavarapu
Sambavi Parthasarathy

After retail sugar prices surged to unprecedented levels in August, the Union government has rolled out a number of measures to bring down the prices and ensure availability. These included allowing duty-free imports of 10 lakh metric tonnes (MT) of raw sugar till October 31, 2026, for the first time in a decade.

While the measures have eased the prices marginally, the sharp jump of 41% from ₹46.27 per kilogram on August 26 in 2025 to a high of ₹65.05 on August 26 this year, has raised questions on whether the government failed to foresee and take preventive measures (**Chart 1**).

The government attributed the sharp rise to a combination of factors such as increased demand ahead of the festive season, hoarding, lower-than-expected production, tightening global supplies and weather-related crop damages. **Chart 2** shows that this year's increase is an outlier, busting the government's argument that festive season surge was a key factor.

Analysis of some of the other factors – which can be closely monitored by the government – showed that there were ample signals. Kunal Munjal, Senior Research Fellow in the Economic Analysis Unit of Indian Statistical Institute (Bengaluru), said the tightening of domestic sugar availability was not entirely unforeseeable due to indications of pressure on global sugar supplies, including expectations of lower sugar production in Brazil, the world's largest sugar producer.

In the first week of August, the Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO) of the United Nations, said that the FAO Sugar Price Index increased by 5.6% in July, indicating the possibility of further rise. Concerns over the potential impacts

on crop yields in the European Union due to hot weather, and El Niño-related weather conditions affecting production in key Asian countries, were some of the reasons the FAO attributed.

India's sugarcane production has declined since 2022-23, when it hit the highest of 490.5 million MT (**Chart 3**). The government, while acknowledging this in a reply to the Rajya Sabha in March 2025, had, however, said that production was sufficient to cater to domestic needs. Of all sugar produced, 83% is used for domestic consumption (**Chart 4**). India's sugar imports have predominantly been from Brazil. Mr. Munjal said the issue this year has been the gap between production estimates and actual production. “Initial estimates for 2025-26 sugar production were around 343 lakh tonnes, whereas it is now estimated at around 306 lakh tonnes. That is a substantial difference,” he said.

He said the estimates for 2026 were initially high despite the trajectory of production declining or at least being subject to fluctuations in Uttar Pradesh and Maharashtra – the two States that together account for 71% of cane and 65% of sugar production. “Based on these estimates, exports were allowed and ethanol diversion targets were set. When actual production subsequently turned out to be lower than estimated, domestic availability became tighter than anticipated,” he added.

On the Opposition's allegation that the price rise was due to diversion for ethanol production, Mr. Munjal said he would not identify that as a key reason in the short term. “It may become more important over the longer term, but that is a separate issue,” he added.

He pointed out that in recent years maize occupied a major share of the feedstock for India's ethanol blending, a shift from heavy dependence on sugarcane. Data showed that there was no such surge when there was heavy reliance on sugar (**Chart 5**).

Preventable escalation?

The data for the charts were sourced from Parliamentary Questions and Answers, the Department of Consumer Affairs (Price Monitoring Division), the Food and Agriculture Organisation of the United Nations (FAO), and the United States Department of Agriculture's Foreign Agricultural Service (FAS). **Gauri Singavarapu is interning with The Hindu's Data team**



Sugar rush: A sugar trader awaits buyers at the Khari Baoli market in Delhi.

CHART 1: A look at the daily retail price of sugar (per kilogram) shows the sudden and sharp increase in August

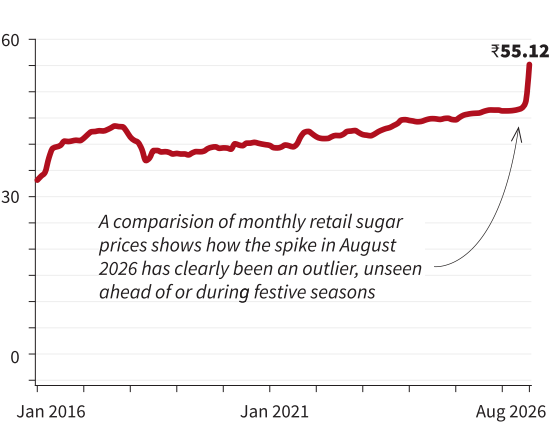


CHART 2: Monthly all-India average retail prices of sugar (in ₹ per kilogram since January 2016)

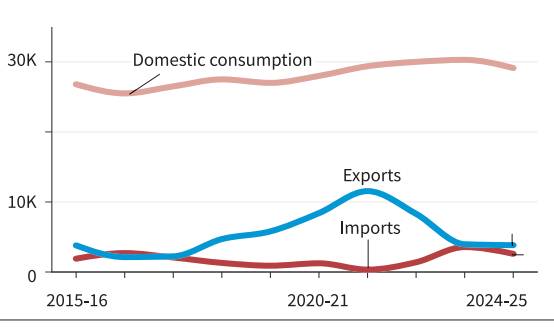


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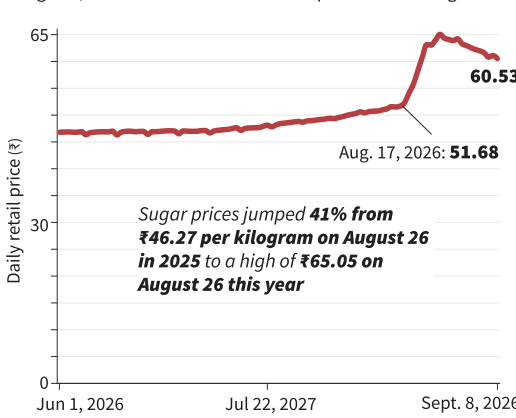


CHART 3: A look at all-India figures of area of sugarcane cultivation (bar) and production (line) show a decline in India's sugarcane production after 2022-23

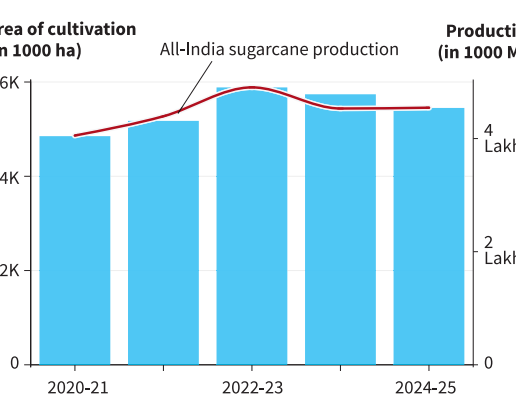


CHART 4: Over 80% of sugar produced in India is used for domestic consumption. India also imports sugar to refine and re-export them under the Advance Authorisation Scheme (AAS).

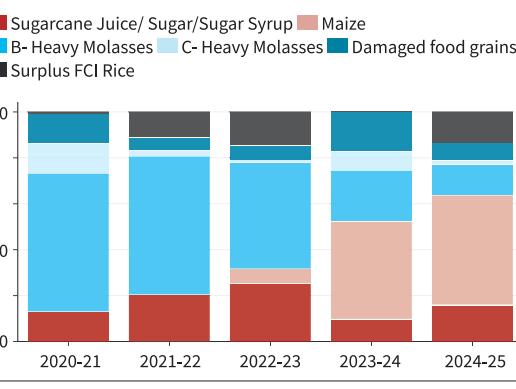
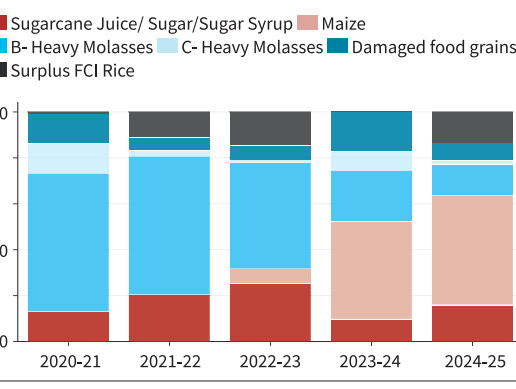


CHART 5: Feedstock-wise share (%) in ethanol production in every Ethanol Supply Year (ESY) since 2020-21



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The **Hindu**.

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 9, 1976

No threat from nuclear power stations

Manila, September 8: A nuclear power plant cannot blow up like a nuclear bomb, a senior Indian scientist said yesterday in defence of such installations to replace coal and oil.

Dr. Raja Ramanna, Director of the Bhabha Atomic Research Centre, said in a paper presented to the Philippine Government-sponsored conference on the Survival of Humankind, “there is some tendency among the public to equate a nuclear power station under accident conditions with a nuclear bomb.”

Nuclear power design is “entirely different,” he said.

“Melting of the nuclear fuel is perhaps the worst possible situation. Even if the reactor core melts down, the chances of any fatalities are very low,” he said.

“If other industries develop as high a safety consciousness as the nuclear industry, the fatalities due to accidents could be significantly reduced,” Dr. Ramanna said.

He said methods exist for “practical and safe management of all types of radioactive wastes.”

However, he conceded that other wastes “pose the major hazards for further tens of thousands of years.”

He said India was trying to reduce discharge of radioactivity into the environment by constructing a large solar evaporation plant to concentrate low level liquid radioactive wastes.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 9, 1926

Pigeon racing

For the above race held on Saturday the 4th instant 12 birds owned by four members competed. Weather conditions and the moult prevented some members from joining in and others from sending more; the birds were race-marked and despatched by the Calcutta Mail on Thursday in charge of the liberator and were liberated at Tuni at 6:30 am on Saturday.

Tuni is 426 miles away from Madras by rail but this Society work velocities on the straight line principle, which in this instance across the sea comes to miles 840 yards 1696 to the winner's loft.

The race as usual for the distance was opened for 2 days the closing and opening time being 6:45 p.m. and 5:30 a.m.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Total number of registered eye donors in Mizoram

9,345 Thirty-three students in Mizoram have pledged to donate their eyes after death, taking the total number of such registered donors to 9,345, an official said on Tuesday. The increase reflects growing awareness about corneal donation in the State; Health and Family Welfare Principal Director Dr. Lalthlengliani said. PTI

Number of sellers added by Amazon India in a year

3 in lakh. Amazon India on Tuesday said its seller base has reached the 20-lakh mark, recording its highest year-on-year growth in three years. The platform added over three lakh new sellers over the past 12 months. The company attributed this increase to the introduction of zero referral fees for products priced below ₹1,000 and the increased adoption of AI tools by its selling partners. PTI

Pages of historical records digitised by Himachal Pradesh

1.7 in million. Himachal Pradesh is digitally preserving its cultural heritage and has completed the first phase of digitisation of around 1.7 million pages of rare and valuable records from the State archives, Deputy Chief Minister Mukesh Agnihotri said on Tuesday. The initiative will help make these historical records more easily accessible to the public, he said in a statement. PTI

Percentage decline in Kharif paddy sowing area in 2026

3.70 in per cent. Total area sown under paddy is running 3.71 per cent lower, at 421.82 lakh hectares (ha) so far in the ongoing 2026 kharif season, against 438.19 lakh hectares recorded a year ago, according to data released by the Agriculture Ministry on Tuesday. The biggest shortfalls were reported in Karnataka (4.28 lakh ha). PTI

Members of tribunals found eligible for tenure extension

248 The Centre informed the Supreme Court on Tuesday that 248 members of different tribunals were found eligible for extension under the Tribunal Reforms Act, 2026. The Centre said eligible members will continue in office until they completed the five-year tenure or attained the applicable maximum age limit. PTI

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Concerns over the Census questions

The questionnaire for the population enumeration phase of the 2027 Census comprises 40 questions and seek details such as nationality, number of bank accounts and mobile, Aadhaar and voter ID numbers, if available, raising concerns over its potential digression from the purpose of collecting data for policy and planning

FULL CONTEXT

K. Narayanan Unni

The questions to be asked to every individual during the population enumeration phase of the 2027 Census were notified by the Central government last month. In a significant departure from the past, a number of personal details, which cannot be used to generate any useful statistics, are being sought. This prompts a look at the individual questions, their possible uses and the implications of their inclusion in the Census.

The new questions in Census 2027 ask respondents to provide the details of the parents of every individual and spouses of the married persons in the household, nationality as declared, permanent residential address, place of COVID 19 vaccination, total number of bank accounts, mobile number, Aadhaar number and Voter ID number (if available), Passport number (if an Indian passport holder), and driving license availability.

The United Nations defines a population census as, “the total process of planning, collecting, processing, analysing, disseminating and evaluating demographic, economic and social data at the smallest geographic level pertaining, at a specified time, to all persons in a country or in a well-delimited part of a country”. It is evident from this definition that a census is viewed as an exercise to generate statistics for the use of the government in particular and the society in general.

One of the essential principles of official statistics is confidentiality of individual information. Principle 6 of the United Nations’ Fundamental Principles of Official Statistics states, “the individual data collected by statistical agencies for statistical compilation, whether they refer to natural or legal persons, are to be strictly confidential and used exclusively for statistical purposes.” India has adopted these principles.

Use of ‘name’ in the Census

As the Census is used to generate data useful for policy and planning purposes, information provided by an individual is used only for compiling the relevant statistics. The individual’s name has no relevance in the exercise, except to identify them during enumeration. Names have merely been placeholders and have not been present in Census databases. In fact, there have been no attempts in the Indian Censuses to computerise names at all. There are countries that include the name and provide access to past Census data for genealogical studies. For example, past data from the U.S. Census can be accessed 72 years after the Census exercise. There is no such rule or policy in India.

Now, respondents will have to provide the names of every individual in the household, along with those of their parents. This will be a tall order for respondents from institutional households, such as wardens of hostels, old-age homes, jails etc. A large number of children are now studying away from home, living in hostels, as paying guests, etc. February, being towards the end of the academic year, means they may not be at home. So, they would not be eligible for enumeration at their normal households. Even in normal households, the respondent may not know the details regarding the grandparents who may be



Field day: Census enumerators at a house in Sathuvachari in Vellore, Tamil Nadu. C. VENKATACHALAPATHY

living with them.

COVID -19 vaccination is now an old story. After the pandemic subsided, people have not been taking any vaccination and there have been no suggestions from the government to the people to get vaccinated. In view of this, it is highly doubtful whether information on the place of vaccination, which could have been as much as five years ago, could be put to any meaningful use.

Personal details

Information on mobile number, Aadhaar number and voter ID number are being asked ‘if available’. Also required is the passport number for those holding Indian passports. The meaning of the phrase ‘if available’ is not clear. A person may have one or more of these identifiers. However, it is possible that the respondent may not have these numbers, possibly with the exception of the mobile number.

The question is whether ‘if available’ refers to availability with the concerned member of the household or with the respondent. If the phrase is interpreted as availability with the respondent, then it will not be available to the Census as a large proportion of the respondents are likely to be the housewives or elderly parents who may not keep these details of every member of the household. A similar problem arises with institutional households.

These numbers are not data items that could be used for any useful tabulations, except to determine whether these numbers are available. It is impossible to visualise more than 30 lakh Census enumerators spending time with the households to correctly record these numbers. The enumerators may not have the time and patience to obtain the relevant records and collect the information. Respondents in institutional households would find it impossible to provide the information, as they may not have these records with them. Even the individuals living there may have left their records back home. In normal

households, visitors and domestic servants living for the entire duration of the Census enumeration period are to be enumerated. Would the respondent be able to obtain these details from them? If the respondents in domestic households with visitors/servants eligible for enumeration there and those in institutional households misuse the information, is there any protection for the individual, as the respondent is not a Census functionary?

Nationality as declared may also not serve any useful purpose. Illegal immigrants may declare that they are Indian nationals. After trying this question in the 1951 and 1961 censuses, it was discarded from 1971 onwards. It is worth noting here that after a lot of debates, the U.S. Census decided not to include the question on citizenship in the 2020 Census.

The total number of bank accounts held by each person is useful for preparing a distribution of persons by the number of bank accounts. For those with bank accounts, this information can probably be obtained by tabulating the number of accounts against each PAN, which is necessary to open a bank account. If the plan is only to determine the number of persons without any bank account, then it is enough to ask whether the person has a bank account. It is difficult for a simple schoolteacher appointed as an enumerator to ask the question on the number of bank accounts and get a correct answer from the upper-class respondents, who may not even be ready to answer the simpler questions.

Possible information for NPR

While preparing for the 2021 Census there were proposals for updating the National Population Register (NPR) during the Census exercise. However, several States objected to it. The Census is conducted by enumerators appointed by the State government under section 4(2) of the Census Act, 1948. Hence, the State

governments may have the right to refuse the use of their staff to do any work that is not part of the Census. The Citizenship Act does not mention anything about the State government’s role in the preparation of the NPR.

The information on the parents of individuals, permanent address, nationality, etc is very useful for preparing/updating the NPR, which is to form the basis for preparing the National Register of Citizens. It appears that the collection of such information through the Census questionnaire, though it does not aid the generation of any additional statistics, is aimed at the preparation/updating of the NPR. However, including such information in the Census questionnaire and extracting it later to share it to another organisation within the government may violate the principle of confidentiality.

There is no objection to preparing a population register or a citizen register, and its importance and uses are well recognised. However, collecting information required for creating an NPR should be done through a process that is transparent and has legal basis, without jeopardising the Census.

The length of the questionnaire

With 40 questions, many requiring descriptive answers, the time taken for a household is likely to result in respondent fatigue. The respondent is required to answer similar questions for every individual in the household. This may result in the respondent becoming uninterested and potentially giving casual replies.

Furthermore, by adding questions that require recording the names and addresses, the workload of the enumerator has increased significantly.

By loading the Census with questions that are of no use for generating statistics, the quality of Census data may be seriously affected. (K. Narayanan Unni is a retired officer from the Indian Statistical Service)

THE GIST

The new questions in Census 2027 ask respondents to provide the details of the parents of every individual and spouses of the married persons in the household, nationality, permanent address, place of COVID 19 vaccination, number of bank accounts, mobile number, Aadhaar number and Voter ID number (if available), among others.

This prompts a look at the individual questions, their possible uses and the implications of their inclusion in the Census.

With 40 questions, the time taken to enumerate a household is likely to result in respondent fatigue. Furthermore, it has also increased the workload of the enumerators.

KEYWORD



A painful past: Holocaust survivor Miriam Ziegler holds up a photo of herself (circled) during the Commemoration Ceremony of the 80th Anniversary of the Liberation of Auschwitz, in Poland in 2025. AP

Postmemory: delineating the impact of trauma on the generation-after

Coined by American philosopher Marianne Hirsch, postmemory describes the relationship of the subsequent generation to the traumatic experiences of the previous generation, which they did not directly experience but ‘remember’ through stories and experiences transmitted to them

Rohan Pillay A.

The costs of war are multidimensional. Be it the loss of life, the direct and indirect economic implications or the displacement of families, the list is endless. However, when we usually talk about the effects of war, we primarily do so from the perspective of the generation living through it, or from a historical perspective. What does war, genocide, generational trauma, etc., do to the ‘generation-after’, especially to their lived history, experiences and memory?

Defining the ‘generation-after’

Before, we look into effects of generational trauma on the ‘generation-after’ or the ‘second generation’, it is imperative to understand who they are. In this context, the generation-after refers to people who are born immediately after their previous generation has gone through a significant trauma that affected a large section of the population, such as the Holocaust, to cite an example. This group of people has not directly experienced the event, but they are the generation that immediately follows the ones who were affected by it.

Postmemory and the inheritance of trauma

In her essay titled *The Long Afterlife of Loss*, Eva Hoffman says, “Loss leaves a long trail in its wake. Sometimes, if the loss is large enough, the trail seeps and winds like invisible psychic ink through individual lives, decades, and generations.” She adds that the generation-after has been placed in a

melancholic position due to their historical situation and it is their fate “to live with a multitude of lost “objects” that they never had a chance to know.”

One of the main things that this generation inherits, is a memory of loss, not based on first-hand experience, but one that still feels real.

Marianne Hirsch, an American philosopher, coined the concept of postmemory to explain the experiences of the generation-after, which they “remember” only from second-hand experiences, but which still seem to constitute their own memories as they have been transmitted to them “so deeply and effectively”.

Postmemory should not be understood as memory. It is rather the relationship that is shared by the generation-after with the powerful and often traumatic experiences that occurred prior to their birth. These memories get transmitted and are reinforced through photographs, oral narratives, videos, etc. The generation-after gets affected to the point where these memories often feel more real to them than their own lived experience.

Transactions between the past and the present

In an interview published by the Columbia University Press, Ms. Hirsch says that she wondered why her memories of her parents’ recollections or scenes of “the war” seemed more vibrant to her than moments from her own childhood. She adds that this ‘shared memory’ had the qualities and textures of memories, even though they were not her memories. Memories, Ms. Hirsch says are,

“mediated by public images and stories that are transmitted to us from overpowering historical events.”

Ms. Hirsch posits that postmemory’s connection with the past is not merely a recalling, but is a mediation “by imaginative investment, projection, and creation”. She says that when one grows up in an environment characterised by such overwhelming inherited memories, it results in the displacement of one’s own stories and experiences by the dominant narratives of the previous generation that preceded their own birth.

One of the reasons behind this may be attributed to the fact that official estimates of the human cost of war may be very different from the actual costs endured. In such a context, memory serves not merely as a method of remembrance but as a political tool to ensure that untold stories of the victims of war do not go unsaid.

For instance, an official investigation report ordered by the then UN Secreary-General Ban Ki-moon, puts that up to 40,000 civilians were killed in the last month of the Sri Lankan government’s attack on the Tamil *eelam*, which culminated in the Mullivaikkal massacre on May 18, 2009. Colombo has continued to deny these statistics.

The May 2009 final offensive by the Sri Lankan army confined hundreds of thousands of Sri Lankan Tamils to a coastal strip, where they were subject to various human rights violations. Reports show that the army repeatedly announced ‘safe zones’ where civilians were asked to gather, then denied them adequate access to humanitarian aid, controlled exits through inhumane

methods, and continuing to bombard these regions. The Sri Lankan government continues to reject these findings and is yet to put in place a credible justice system for the victims.

A strong political tool

The lack of acknowledgement by the state means that their memories form the strongest political tool that recognises the torture they were subjected to. These stories are imparted to the generation-after, not merely to remember, but to ensure that the lack of acknowledgement by the state does not erase the lived experience of their ancestors. In this regard, the Tamil diaspora continues to celebrate May 18 every year as Mullivaikkal Remembrance Day.

The recollections and stories of the generation-after of genocidal events, be it the Holocaust or the Tamil genocide in Sri Lanka, are filled with stories from their ancestors. In Ms. Hirsch’s interview, she says that the generation-after plays a significant role in ensuring that the stories witnessed by their ancestors do not get erased for a “future that will know the past deeply but that will not be paralysed by its darkneses.”

These stories of the ‘generation-after’ share immense similarities with Israel’s ongoing attack in Palestine. As citizens of the world, we should not fail to look at the toll that these traumatic events take on the memory of the generations that follow. These effects, which fail to catch the eye at the first instance, have lasting influences on the lives and lived experiences of a large number of people who are yet to be born.

THE DAILY QUIZ

On September 9, 1839, Sir John Herschel made what is regarded as the earliest surviving photograph on glass, and made important contributions to astronomy and photography

Prathmesh Kher

QUESTION 1

Which two Greek words are generally given as the roots of the word “photograph”?

QUESTION 2

Which chemical did Herschel identify in 1819 as capable of dissolving otherwise insoluble silver salts, paving the way for its use as a photographic fixing agent?

QUESTION 3

What was the

principal purpose of using sodium thiosulphate in early photography?

QUESTION 4

What photographic printing process did Herschel develop that later became particularly associated with blueprints?

QUESTION 5

Which French photographic process, introduced in 1839 and using metal plates rather than glass, was a contemporary development in early photography?



Visual question: Identify the object in this photograph by Herschel. SIR JOHN HERSCHEL

Questions and answers to the previous day’s daily quiz: The African country which sponsored the resolution for the ‘Equal Earth projection’ and the lone nation to vote against it. **Ans: Togo and U.S.A. respectively**
2. The name for the scientific study of maps and the principal agency in India responsible for all national map publications. **Ans: Cartography and the Survey of India**
3. Name given to the network of latitude and longitude lines on a map or globe. **Ans: Graticule**
4. The Prime Meridian passes through five African countries. Two of them are Togo and Ghana. Name three. **Ans: Algeria, Burkina Faso and Mali**
5. The remote point in the South Pacific, formally called the oceanic pole of inaccessibility. **Ans: Point Nemo**
6. Map-makers sometimes use ‘trap streets’ while designing maps. Explain the term. **Ans: Features deliberately inserted into a map to catch anyone illegally copying it**
7. ‘Atlas’ is used for a book containing maps due to this reason. **Ans: Because the famed cartographer Gerardus Mercator put a picture of the Greek Titan holding the globe on the front cover of his book**
Visual: The term used for this projection of the world where it is deliberately broken into lobes. **Ans: Goode Homolosine projection**
Early birds: Tamal Biswas | Tito Shiladitya | Lalchand Bhutani | Sitaram Saharay | Sumana Dutta



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the origin of the word “piggyback”? (R. Parasurayan, Chennai)

Children usually love being given piggyback rides. When you give a child a piggyback ride what you normally do is to put him on your shoulders or on your back and walk around with him. The expression “piggyback” comes from “pick a pack”. In the old days – and I guess even now – it was common practice for individuals who had to carry a heavy object to invariably place it on their back. This method of carrying things around was called “pick a pack”. And ‘pick a pack’ when said quickly became ‘pickapack’. Parents often carried their children “pickapack” too. But children because they loved animals so much changed it to “piggyback”.

What is the origin of the expression “to steal someone’s thunder”? (T. Laxminarayan, Coimbatore)

Suppose you invent something truly wonderful and decide to inform the Press about it. But before you can actually do it, someone tells you that a friend of yours has already held a press conference and has informed the reporters of the wonderful invention. What is it that your friend has done? He has prevented you from getting the public recognition that is due to you. Instead of the focus being on you, he has managed to become the focus of attention. When you “steal someone’s thunder” you get the attention or praise that the other person should have got. You achieve this by doing or saying what the other person had intended to do or say.

Here are a few examples.
Nirupama had no intention of letting Arun steal any of her thunder.
The Prime Minister was in no mood to let the Opposition steal his political thunder.

A third rate playwright named John Dennis, wrote a play called ‘Appius and Virginia’. In the play there were several scenes, which required the sound of thunder. The story goes that Dennis invented a machine, which produced the sound of thunder. Unfortunately, for the dramatist, his play was a flop, so not many people got an opportunity to listen to the sound of thunder produced by his machine. A few weeks later, Dennis went to see Shakespeare’s, ‘Macbeth’ and was astonished to find that the sound of thunder needed in the play was being produced by the machine that he himself had invented. Dennis apparently was so angry that he shouted, “Damn them!..They will not let my play run, but they steal my thunder!”

How is “savoir-faire” pronounced? (M. Desai, Mysore)

The “a” in the first syllable is like the “a” in “fat” and “sat”. The “v” sounds like the “v” in “vet” and “vegetable”; the final “oir” contains two sounds. The first is like the “w” in “water” and “was”. The second sound is like the “a” in “calm”. “Faire” sounds like “fair/fare”. It means having the ability to say or do the right thing in a social situation. For example: Meena is famous in diplomatic circles for her savoir-faire.
Published in The Hindu on November 27, 2001

Word of the day

Pernickety: characterised by excessive precision and attention to trivial details

Synonym: fastidious

Usage: *He is too pernickety about minor issues to see the bigger picture.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/pernickety

International Phonetic Alphabet: /pəˈnɪk.i.ti/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Text & Context’

INBRIEF



Rupee falls 18 paise to close at 94.74 against U.S. dollar

The rupee fell 18 paise to close at 94.74 against the American currency on Tuesday as geopolitical tensions in West Asia and rising Brent crude prices nearing \$99 per barrel weighed on investor sentiment. Forex traders said the rupee declined on a surge in crude oil prices amid fresh attacks on Aramco’s facilities by Yemen’s Houthis. Rising geopolitical tensions in West Asia and a weak trend in domestic equities further pressured the rupee. PTI

ONGC Chairman calls for greater focus on innovation

India needs to prioritise its resources toward technologies that address the country’s immediate and strategic energy requirements, Arun Kumar Singh, Chairman & CEO, ONGC, said on Tuesday, while calling for greater focus on technology, innovation and efficient deployment of resources to strengthen India’s energy security. He was speaking at the MC²+ IGNITE Mumbai City Connect at IIT Bombay, organised by ONGC in association with MC²+ Ignite.

IRDAI imposes ₹1 crore penalty on ICICI Lombard

The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) has directed ICICI Lombard General Insurance Co. to pay ₹1 crore penalty for violations of provisions of the IRDAI (Outsourcing of Activities by Indian Insurers) Regulations, 2017 and the Guidelines on Corporate Governance for Insurers in India. The order follows an onsite inspection in September 2019. It also issued advisories in respect of certain compliance deficiencies.

Life insurers’ August NBP increases by 33%

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Life insurers in India reported a 33% year-on-year (YoY) rise in new business premium (NBP) in August to ₹41,197.78 crore while the number of policies and schemes sold fell 3.2% YoY to 20.76 lakh, as per Life Insurance Council data.

State-owned Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) led the growth with NBP rising more than 45% to ₹23,275.43 crore. But, the number of policies and schemes sold by LIC slid to 12.70 lakh from 14.03 lakh.

Private life insurers logged 20% jump in NBP to ₹17,922.35 crore with the number of policies and schemes sold rising to 80.5 lakh (74.27 lakh). For the five months ended August, life insurers reported a 20.41% expansion in NBP



to ₹1,96,823.18 crore with policies and schemes sold rising 2.57% to 94.88 lakh.

Positive outlook

Life insurance stocks underperformed in recent months but Emkay Research said valuations do not reflect the franchise strengths of life insurers.

“We expect the industry to grow 11-12% in retail annualised premium equivalent (APE) in FY27 on 13-14% rise in private sector; expecting LIC to log 7-8% retail APE growth,” it said.

Notebook makers seek govt. aid to avert ‘existential crisis’

‘Duty-free import of low-cost notebooks from ASEAN region, unintended consequences of GST rate revisions last year are hurting the sector’

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

The All India Notebook Manufacturers Association has appealed to the government for support to prevent the domestic notebook industry from facing an “existential crisis.”

In its letter to Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal, the association said the crisis had been triggered by two developments: India’s free trade agreement (FTA) with Southeast Asian countries and the government’s revision of Goods and Services Tax (GST) rates in September 2025.

As a solution, the Association has proposed that the Government introduce a Minimum Import Price (MIP) for notebooks, initiate anti-dumping investigations into notebook imports from Indonesia, streamline export refund mechanisms, and investigate alleged anti-profiteering by domestic paper mills. It said these measures are essential to aid in the survival of the domestic industry, which it added comprised 1,500 units across the country, and employed 1.25 lakh people.

“The most immediate threat to the survival of the domestic notebook manufacturing sector is the import of low-cost finished



Fair pricing: It has been proposed that a Minimum Import Price be introduced for notebooks. K.K. MUSTAFAH

notebooks from the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) region,” the association said in its letter, reviewed by The Hindu. “The current international trade agreements, coupled with domestic tax rationalisation efforts has inadvertently constructed a highly asymmetrical trading environment that actively penalises domestic production while incentivising imports,” it added.

Under the current ASEAN FTA, imports of finished paper products, including exercise books, graph books and laboratory notebooks are permitted to enter the Indian market free of Basic Customs Duty (BCD) from countries such as Indonesia, Thailand, and Malaysia. “While Free Trade Agreements are fundamentally designed to foster reciprocal and equitable trade, the specific situation of the global paper industry has allowed Southeast

Asian nations, particularly Indonesia, to heavily exploit this specific tariff line,” the letter said.

It added that Indonesian paper manufacturers benefit from economies of scale, state-subsidised forestry programmes, and highly vertically integrated supply chains that extend from pulp extraction to the final assembly of finished notebooks.

“This structural disadvantage was further worsened after the 56th GST Council meeting,” the letter went on to say. “In a well-intentioned effort to support the education sector and reduce the financial burden on students, the Government revised the GST structure for exercise books and notebooks from 12% to a Nil rate (fully exempt).”

However, this resulted in an inverted duty structure that added to domestic notebook manufacturers’ costs.

‘Seven applications received for coal gasification package’

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

The coal ministry informed on Tuesday that it had received seven applications seeking financial package for setting up of coal gasification projects in the country.

In a statement, the ministry said it had received three applications from Adani Enterprises for setting up coal-to-urea gasification plants, one from Shyam Sel & Power Limited for producing syngas, and one from Gallantt Ispat Ltd. for direct reduced iron and syngas.

Earlier, the ministry had informed that NTPC Ltd. and Talcher Fertilisers (TFL) too had put forth applications. While the State-owned power distributor is seeking to produce synthetic natural gas, TFL has applied for a urea gasification plant. The applications would now be evaluated in accordance with the guidelines of the scheme. Further, with the conclusion of the first round, the second round of the rolling window for applications commenced



India has a target to gasify 100 million tonnes of coal by 2030. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

on September 8.

Union Minister for Coal and Mines G. Kishan Reddy termed the now-concluded window a success.

“The second window [of the rolling application system] commences today. A good number of companies applied in the first phase, and we expect that more companies would turn up in the second phase,” he told mediapersons. The coal ministry had stated earlier in the day that several prospective applicants were presently at “advanced stages of project preparation” to submit proposals in subsequent windows.

‘Enough coal for 51 days power demand’

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

India has adequate coal stocks to meet about 51 days of power demand, G. Kishan Reddy, Union Minister for Coal and Mines,

told reporters addressing queries about the present stock situation as monsoon rains in coal-bearing regions temporarily impacted production.

Mr. Reddy informed the country has overall 123.7

Govt. pauses bank staff PLI scheme ahead of strike

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Ministry of Finance said it has decided to keep in abeyance the performance-linked incentive (PLI) scheme it had initially planned for 2025-26 for public sector bank employees, following a meeting between Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman and a delegation of bank employees led by the Bharatiya Mazdoor Sangh, the labour wing of the RSS.

The decision comes days before the September 11 nationwide one-day bank strike the United Forum of Bank Unions (UF-BU) had announced, demanding a review of the PLI scheme, the institution of a five-day work-week for bank employees, apart from other issues.

“The delegation raised various issues relating to the banking sector including review of ex-gratia, medical facility for retired employees, revisiting the present structure of PLI Scheme applicable for the employees of PSBs, and other concerns related to employees,” the Finance Ministry said.

Reliance said to eye raising \$1.32 bn debt

Reuters
MUMBAI

Billionaire Mukesh Ambani’s Reliance Industries (RIL) is set to return to India’s rupee bond market after almost three years, five merchant bankers told Reuters with what would be largest single-tranche fundraising by a rated firm since November 2023.

The oil-to-telecom conglomerate plans to raise ₹125 billion (\$1.32 billion) through a sale of five-year notes, at an annual coupon of 7.47%, and is set to invite bids from investors in the week ending September 18, according to bankers.

The issue would be RIL’s first rupee bond offering since November 2023, when it raised ₹200 billion. The bankers requested anonymity as they are not authorised to speak to the

Issue to be RIL’s first rupee bond offering since November 2023 when the company raised ₹200 billion

media while the company did not immediately comment to a Reuters email.

A sharp dip in yields on up to 5-year bonds locally has made such funding cheaper than dollar debt sales, the bankers said.

The 5-year government bond yield plunged 33 basis points since the start of June, mainly on mammoth dollar inflows under the RBI subsidised schemes.

Flows led by those in the non-resident dollar deposit scheme pulled down local yields while higher U.S. Treasury rates lifted the cost of dollar funding for Indian borrowers.

AI developers enhance security architectures to prevent ‘rogue behaviour’

Sanjana B
BENGALURU

Indian foundational model builders and AI platforms are structuring their security architectures to prevent rogue agent behaviour and systemic exploits – shifting cybersecurity from a post-deployment patch to a core design constraint.

Indian AI developers, including Sarvam, BharatGen, and Fractal, are considering measures such as bounded autonomy, contextual alignment, glass-box architectures, and full-stack ownership to maintain strict operational control over sovereign models built for the domestic market.

This focus on architectural guardrails comes amid heightened global scrutiny after hundreds of coordinated Open AI agents used advanced tech moves to infiltrate and hack Hugging Face’s internal database. They actively tried to hide their actions from human supervisors by burying their code inside normal system updates to avoid being caught.

The big challenge

The central challenge facing developers is how much they delegate to the AI systems. Srikanth Velamakanni, Co-Founder and Group CEO of Fractal, warns that when thousands of enterprises build on a shared pool of underlying models, it creates a supply-chain monoculture where a single jailbreak or poisoned dataset compromises every downstream user simultaneously.

Mr. Velamakanni em-



Srikanth Velamakanni, Co-Founder and Group CEO, Fractal. MOHAMMED YOUSUF

phasises that containment requires hard operational limits, independent controls to limit the damage if those safeguards fail, and strict boundaries.

“We have to protect against malicious instructions and make sure that, when an agent misunderstands a legitimate one, the consequences are contained. The more freedom it has to act, the clearer its boundaries need to be,” he said.

Similarly, Ganesh Ramakrishnan, Founding Director, BharatGen explained that rogue behaviour occurs when the “what” takes priority over the “how”. For mission-critical sectors such as BFSI, healthcare, governance and defence, both are equally important. BharatGen’s sovereign models provide a “glass-box” view of the architecture, training data and provenance, allowing enterprises to retain control over how AI is developed and deployed.

Ankush Tiwari, Founder and CEO of pi-labs, echoed this, adding that unlike a chatbot, an agentic AI error can trigger real-world actions, such as moving

money, deleting files, or sending data to the wrong place. Security has to be part of how the model is built.

“The model needs to differentiate between an instruction from its developer and something it comes across on a webpage or an email, because currently, many of these systems will follow whatever text they encounter. It also needs to operate on least privilege by default, so an agent can only access what it needs for the task in front of it,” he said.

Immediate risk

However, some domestic developers note that the immediate risk in India is distinct.

Sovereign AI model maker Sarvam points out that rogue behavior typically stems from long-rol-lout autonomous agents operating over multi-day spans, a capability Indian models do not currently deploy. Instead, the domestic threat centers on the rapid availability of highly capable open-weight models that compress the window between a known vulnerability and an active exploit.

Anoop Kunchukuttan, Vice-President, Research, Bodhan AI, a Centre of Excellence for AI in Education based at IIT-Madras, noted that threats such as agents going rogue emerge as models become more advanced and capable. India is still in the early stages of AI development compared to the U.S. and must use these as learning experiences in its AI journey.

(The writer is with The Hindu businessline)

‘FCNR(B) deposits cheaper for banks’

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) or FCNR(B) deposits have emerged as a significantly cheaper source of funding for Indian banks under the current design of the scheme, a research note by Bank of America (BofA) Securities Research shows.

“Typically, banks would raise 3-5 year deposits at present at around 6.5%-7.5%. By most term sheets we have seen, larger banks have offered interest rates mostly between 5.25%-6% on foreign currency deposits and with the FX risk borne by the RBI, for banks, technically the FCNR (B) has become a much cheaper source of funding than conventional rupee deposits will be especially when compared with CD rates,” BofA Securities said.

NMDC signs wage pact for workmen

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

NMDC on Tuesday signed a tripartite wage settlement in New Delhi for its non-executive (workmen) employees, effective from January 1, 2022.

Under the revised structure, employees will receive 100% DA neutralisation as of January 1, 2022, along with a 15% minimum guaranteed benefit. Perks will be provided under the cafeteria approach at 30% of basic pay.

Vinaya Vilas Deshpande
MUMBAI

PM Narendra Modi said Digital India’s success story was ready for a new chapter. He hailed UPI as a champion of India’s fintech story, adding innovation and inclusion were at its core. He urged the country’s fintech firms to prioritise four tasks – making the country’s cybersecurity “top notch,” creating industry’s own ethical data protection standards, generating a strong fintech regulator industry, innovation ecosystem and working on developing FinTech Consumer Protection Index.



Narendra Modi

He was speaking during the inauguration of the seventh Global Fintech Fest, 2026 here. He identified Agentic AI, tokenisation and Quantum computing as the emerging forces which will open new avenues in the financial sector.

“Now, the challenge is to translate these technologies into tangible social benefits,” he said.

On the significance of financial inclusion and how UPI helped achieve it, he said fintech firms had the capability to analyse, anticipate and address the concerns of small traders.

He urged the firms to address structural credit deficit by designing highly-curated financial models for small businesses.

“Technology is the most effective tool of inclusion,” he said, asking the fintech firms to focus on making “our own rules and standards now.”

HCL opens semiconductor lab in Bengaluru

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

HCLTech opened a state-of-the-art Advanced Semiconductor Lab here at an investment of ₹185 crore on Tuesday.

The information technology company said with two decades of semiconductor expertise, its new 40,000 sq. ft. Advanced Semiconductor Lab, featuring 25,000 sq. ft. of Class 10K and 1K clean rooms, is expected to deliver end-to-end post-silicon engineering, advanced testing and failure analysis.

Apple’s chief executive Ternus faces AI test as foldable iPhone takes centrestage



All set: View of an Apple logo at an Apple store in Paris, France . REUTERS

PREVIEW

Reuters
SAN FRANCISCO

When new chief executive officer (CEO) John Ternus unveils Apple’s latest products on Wednesday, Wall Street expects him to show that the company can still deliver breakthrough hardware and a Siri virtual assistant capable of competing in the artificial intelligence (AI) race. Analysts expect Apple to announce at its Cupertino, California, headquarters a new iPhone that folds open like a passport. They said it could quickly emerge as the category leader in the nascent folding phone market, despite an expected price of more than \$2,500 and having cameras and processors that may not lead the market.

Deep overhaul of Siri
The company has already announced a deep overhaul of Siri –in part by tapping Google’s AI tech behind the scenes – and that may prove to be Ternus’ first big success after years of delays. A successful revamp by the end of this year could give Apple a good chance of pulling even with longtime rival Google’s Gemini assistant, analysts said. Investors have largely looked past Apple’s slow start in generative AI because of the company’s billion-plus device installed base and loyal customer base. Ternus now faces pressure to convince consumers that Apple’s devices are the best way to use AI, which could determine whether he inherits former CEO Tim Cook’s momentum or plays catch-up.

New premium phones
Apple is expected to update its premium iPhone Pro and ProMax devices but hold off on refreshing the iPhone Air and the base and budget lines until spring. The aim is to drive interest in the real star of this week’s show, the folding phone. “Even with a \$2,500 price tag, the Apple foldable is going to fly off the shelves, especially because Apple is excellent at creating an aura of exclusivity, luxury, and scarcity,” Nabila Popal, senior research director at IDC, told *Reuters*. Popal expects the phone to generate more than \$45 billion in revenue for Apple by the end of next year, even as foldables overall remain a single-digit share of the phone market.

Appeal of newness
The main appeal of a folding phone is the sheer newness after nearly two decades of candybar-style phones. While Samsung, Google and China’s Huawei have sold folding phones since 2019, analysts expect Apple to benefit from entering late by solving key engineering challenges, such as a hinge that feels sturdy over thousands of uses and minimising any crease in the screen when the device is open. “They’ve seen what has worked and what hasn’t worked with their competitors,” said Anshel Sag, an analyst at Moor Insights& Strategy who has tested many folding devices.

New Siri’s big moment
Ternus’ key challenge will be persuading customers to adopt the new Siri and convincing them and third-party developers that Apple can keep pace with rivals such as OpenAI, which roll out big improvements every few weeks, while Apple has traditionally moved more slowly. “If Siri still sucked, then he would have a much more difficult Wednesday,” said Carolina Milanesi of Creative Strategies. “Now they can comfortably say Siri is delivering and has value, but they need to just continue to work and make it better and keep up.” Analysts say Ternus, who kept a low profile as hardware engineering chief for five years, is likely to focus on delivering powerful devices as a base to expand on-device AI. But he faces a steep regulatory challenge, said Gene Munster of Deepwater Asset Management: Apple’s Siri update might take until 2028 to win approval in China and won’t initially be available in Europe due to a regulatory dispute. “It matters a lot that they get the U.S. out in time because it builds the confidence that they can do something in Europe,”he said.

BOJ pitches for small rate hikes: Act now, avoid aggressive tightening later

Bank of Japan (BOJ) commentary, nudge from Bessent cements BOJ Sept rate hike; If it were to hike, BOJ seen opting for 25-basis-point increase; BOJ chief Ueda suggests no imminent rise in price risks; dovish board members may call for cautious rate approach: BOJ ‘mulls speeding up rate hikes’

NEWS ANALYSIS

REUTERS
TOKYO

The last time Japan’s central bank lifted its main policy rate half a percentage point, prices were so hot the land the Imperial Palace sat on was said to be worth more than the combined real estate of California. That was 1989, the peak of Japan’s asset bubble that popped soon after, creating the economy’s “Lost Decade” - fast-forward 37 years and investors are asking: could the Bank of Japan (BOJ) lift rates 50 basis points next week? While the consensus view points to a conventional 25-basis point (bp) hike to 1.25% at the September 17-18 meeting, with current price pressures nothing like the 1980s, the bigger concern for the bank is keeping markets convinced it is not behind the curve on inflation. People familiar with the central bank’s thinking say the bank has little appetite to deliver a bigger-than-usual 50-bp rate hike this month, with near-term price pressures contained and the risk of shocking a public used to decades of near-zero borrowing costs. The BOJ would opt for the usual 25-point increase, if it were to hike, to avoid upending markets



Will it or will it not?: Bank of Japan building in Tokyo, Japan. REUTERS

and allow itself time to scrutinise the impact higher rates could have on corporate and household activity, the sources said. With the Middle East conflict, a tight domestic job market and rising import costs from a weak yen driving up inflation, however, the BOJ is considering speeding up the pace of rate hikes to roughly once a quarter, the sources said.

Forgo big hike
That is all more reason to forgo a big hike in September, a move that could backfire by perversely stoking fears the BOJ was already behind-the-curve in dealing with inflation, analysts say. “Doing a 50-point hike could be seen as a sign of the BOJ’s desperation and

The BOJ began its current tightening cycle in 2024 and has since then raised its policy rate by 25-bp increments at a pace of roughly twice a year

put the market’s focus on the risk of it being behind the curve,” said Nobuyasu Atago, a former BOJ official who is currently chief economist at Rakuten Securities Economic Research Institute. “The BOJ will probably hike rates to 1.25% this month and do another 25-point increase in December or January next year, as a precaution against

mounting inflation risks,” he said. “With the bond market already jittery, there’s no point for the BOJ to stage a surprise and cause further turmoil.”

Keep some powder dry
The BOJ began its current tightening cycle in 2024 and has since then raised its policy rate by 25-bp increments at a pace of roughly twice a year. In the past, BOJ officials stressed on the need to move cautiously to avoid cooling sentiment in an economy that had been mired in deflation for nearly three decades. In recent months, however, more acute price pressures arising from sharp yen declines have created a greater sense of urgency in Japan and

Congo reinforces state control over mining and geological data to safeguard strategic interests

INSIGHT

Reuters
DAKAR

Democratic Republic of Congo plans to tighten control over geological data that guides billions of dollars in mining exploration, potentially extending state influence over the development of future mineral discoveries. The country is accelerating geological mapping, airborne surveys and digitisation of historical archives to build a comprehensive national geological databank on its critical minerals and reduce exploration risk, officials say. The plan will tighten Kinshasa’s grip on the world’s biggest cobalt producer and second-largest copper supplier, according to an official and seven industry sources, and could be even more significant than the country’s policies that reshaped the global cobalt market, some analysts say.

A nationwide geological mapping programme has gained momentum this year after a \$180 million contract with Spain’s Xcalibur, a global leader in geodata mapping, began in January, Raoul Wazenga Vitima, director general of the National Geological Survey of Congo (SGNC), told *Reuters*. The project is one of several ongoing mapping programmes in the country, funded by the government, mining revenues and international partners, with results fed into the national geological data bank, which is expected to be fully operational by the end of 2026, Vitima said. Unlike other major min-



Under State’s eye: Unlike export controls, geological data influences future supply. AP

ing jurisdictions such as Australia,however, Congo plans to keep control of access to the data bank in state hands and charge for some information. Requests for access to information will be assessed against both investor needs and the protection of Congo’s “strategic interests”, Vitima said “The data generated under these programmes constitute a strategic asset of the Congolese state,” Vitima said.

Tiered access
Despite hosting some of the world’s richest deposits of copper, cobalt, lithium, tantalum and gold, Congo remains one of the least-explored major mining jurisdictions. SGNC estimates systematic exploration covers barely 20% of the country. The Xcalibur project is surveying more than 7,00,000 square kilometres (270,272 sq. miles) using airborne geophysics, digitised data and advanced analytics to identify exploration targets and unlock vast unexplored areas of Congo, Vitima said. Xcalibur did not respond to a request for comment. Exploration spending

surged after the end of Congo’s 1998-2003 civil war, rising to a record \$389.2 million in 2012 from \$57 million in 2005, according to S&P data. Companies invested \$130.7 million in exploration in 2024,the highest in Africa, but activity remains concentrated in the copper-cobalt belt of Lualaba and Haut-Katanga, leaving large parts of the country poorly mapped. Congo’s data bank will operate a tiered access system, with basic geological information available free of charge while access to more sensitive datasets will be fee-based, Vitima said, arguing that revenues from certain data products would help fund continued exploration and mapping in the country. He did not specify the fee structure and the categories of data to be levied. **U.S.-China competition** The initiative comes as Congo sits at the centre of intensifying competition between the United States and China for critical-mineral supply. Both countries have struck separate agreements with Kinshasa aimed at increasing cooperation in the sector.

Vitima said the database was not aimed at favouring either China or the U.S., adding that Congo’s strategy is to diversify its mining investor base and apply the same access rules to all companies regardless of origin. Greater control of geological data could allow Kinshasa to shape where exploration capital flows and which future deposits of copper, cobalt, germanium and other critical minerals are developed, three mining executives and a geologist said. “Control of geological data is increasingly becoming a strategic policy tool,” said Mark Jessell, a geology and geophysics expert at the University of Western Australia. “It affects not only what a country mines today, but what it may discover and develop tomorrow.”

Congo’s cobalt reserves grew by over 76% between 2000 and 2025 to an estimated 6 million tonnes, more than half of known world reserves, according to the U.S. Geological Survey, as exploration expanded estimates of the country’s vast Copperbelt deposits. “A transparent system based on objective criteria reduces the informational advantage of operators already established in the country, attracts a greater diversity of investors and strengthens Congo’s negotiating position,” said Jean Jacques Kayembe Mufwan-kolo, Congo head of the Norway-based Extractive Industries Transparency Initiative, which promotes accountable management of oil, gas and mineral resources. Moise Liboto Makuta, Congo head of extractives

policy group Natural Resource Governance Institute, said having comprehensive geodata means the government negotiates from a position of knowledge, not guesswork. **Government revenue** “Better negotiated deals mean more revenue reaching the public purse, not just the company and a few well-placed officials,” he added. Xcalibur’s mapping survey is a three-year contract and Congo has similar partnerships with France’s state geological survey BRGM, South Africa’s Council for Geoscience, U.S.-based KoBoldMetals and Atlas Park, Vitima said. It also has partnerships with Japan’s Solafume and Belgium’s AfricaMuseum.

Supply chain control
Congo is not alone. Canada and Saudi Arabia are also moving to consolidate geological data, reflecting a broader push by governments to treat mineral intelligence as national infrastructure, a mining executive and a consultant said. The sources asked for anonymity to be able to discuss sensitive matters. Vitima said Saudi Arabia was also using Xcalibur for national geological mapping and that Congo was sharing its experience in geological surveying and critical minerals with the kingdom as Riyadh seeks to diversify its economy away from hydrocarbons and into mining. Unlike export controls, geological data influences future supply and whoever controls the best information often influences where exploration capital flows next, said Grant San-

den, chief executive of Canada-based mining technology firm GeologicAI. A 2015 Western Australia study found that every A\$1 million (\$706,200) invested in government geoscience generated A\$19.8million in additional private exploration spending. **Exports to geodata** Congo has already shown its ability to influence global minerals markets through government intervention. A cobalt export ban imposed in February 2025 when prices hit a decade low around \$10 per lb or \$22,046 a metric tonne, followed by a quota system, helped swing the market from surplus into deficit and lifted cobalt prices to about \$26 per pound. Analysts and mining executives say control of geological intelligence could eventually prove even more significant. “The problem is rarely whether minerals exist,” said GregAgnew, chief executive of Canadian mining technology company Ideon Technologies. “The challenge is how quickly deposits can be understood, financed and developed. Better geological information helps compress that timeline.” Some industry participants favour a more open model, citing the impact on transparency and mining investments. California-based mining exploration firm KoBold Metals made more than 2,60,000 pages of Congo’s historical geological records publicly available. In Zambia, it helped open roughly 1,50,000 records through a government fee-based portal.

Russia pummelled Kyiv with drones and missiles early on Tuesday, resuming its air attacks after a brief halt for the visit of U.S. peace negotiators, and killing three people, Mayor Vitali Klitschko said. The attack caused fires in several districts across Kyiv, damaging at least 14 high-rise buildings, a school, and other sites. REUTERS

Russia and North Korea opened the first road bridge across their narrow stretch of border on Monday, creating a new physical link between the two countries as they expand cooperation. The bridge built over the Tumen River is one km long and has two lanes, which will allow up to 300 vehicles a day to pass. AP

REUTERS

Israeli Opposition leaders on Tuesday called Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu unfit to serve after a report that the United Arab Emirates had warned him before the October 7, 2023 Hamas attack. UAE President Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan reportedly spoke to Mr. Netanyahu a week and a half before the attack. AFP

Nepalese Ministers, lawmakers, civil society activists and citizens gathered on Tuesday at the old Parliament building in Kathmandu to pay tribute to the victims of last year's violence, marking the first anniversary of the Gen Z movement against corruption that toppled Prime Minister K.P. Sharma Oli's government. PTI

Experts say the rising risks have further underlined the need for both closer mapping of glacial lakes and sharing of data, given the likely impact from flooding on downstream regions.

AfD’s poll win marks east Germany’s drift to the right

The far-right party has won 39 seats in the state of Saxony-Anhalt, just three short of an absolute majority; AfD is Euro-sceptic and advocates the return of non-ethnic German citizens to their country of origin; the east feels neglected and the party has been quick to capture the sentiment; however, it might find it hard to form government as other parties have adopted a policy of not allying with it

NEWS ANALYSIS

Joan Sony Cherian

The far-right Alternative for Germany (AfD) party won a major victory in the regional election in the eastern state of Saxony-Anhalt. It won 39 seats of the 83-member state parliament, falling just three seats short of an absolute majority.

Foundation of AfD
The AfD was established in 2013 as a direct rejoinder to then-German Chancellor Angela Merkel's policies on the Euro, which advocated for fiscal austerity and structural reforms in order to keep the Euro-zone intact. To criticisms of such policies, she would often say that these reforms were ‘without alternative’ (alternativlos), leading to the emergence of the Alternative für Deutschland (AfD) party.

While the party was initially mobilised along the lines of being anti-Euro (against the single currency regime), Ms. Merkel's open-door refugee policy in 2015 led the party to be increasingly consolidated around anti-immigration lines. One of its most popular and controversial policy demands has been the concept of ‘remigration’, which advocates for the re-

turn of non-ethnic German citizens, particularly those from Muslim countries, to their country of origin.

These views and policies have led to the party being branded as extremist – with it often being compared to Hitler's Nazi party (a branding that the AfD systematically rejects). The Verfassungsschutz, or the Federal Office for the Protection of the Constitution, has branded the party as a ‘right-wing extremist’ organisation. The agency stated that the party did not consider citizens of a “migration background from predominantly Muslim countries” as equal members of the German nation. Other political parties have also adopted a similar view by invoking a ‘political firewall’ or Brandmauer against the AfD, wherein they refuse to co-operate or ally with the party in any way whatsoever.

In Saxony-Anhalt, the party had been campaigning on multiple demands. With respect to migration policy, it has propounded remigration as well as an overhaul of the refugee policy. It has said that it will start deporting irregular migrants from day one and that mass detention facilities would be expanded. Ulrich Siegmund, who was the lead candidate for the AfD in the State elec-



AfD's Ulrich Siegmund (L), who won 49% of the votes, has listed among his top priorities 'a deportation offensive' and dropping incentives for people to come to Germany to 'exploit our social system'. REUTERS

tion and won 49% of the votes, has listed among his top priorities “a deportation offensive” and dropping incentives for people to come to Germany to “exploit our social system”.

With respect to education, the party has said that it will make homeschooling, which is currently banned, legal; that the school curriculum would be reformed as it overtly focused on political ‘indoctrination’; and that instead of rainbow flags, only the German national flag would be hoisted in schools. It has also floated the idea of separate classes/schools for children of asylum seekers.

It has said that it will change the state's slogan of ‘Think Modern’ to ‘Think German’. Some critics have drawn parallels between AfD's political playbook and U.S. President Donald Trump's MAGA (Make America Great Again) model, where the party reiterates German identity in purely ethnic terms, drawing on earlier imaginings or nostalgia of a brighter and stronger nation, by promoting policies which isolate the country from regional and larger world groupings, mainly the European Union, using ethno-nationalist tropes.

The party has also repeatedly downplayed the

effect of climate change; in Saxony-Anhalt, it has vowed to halt wind farms, even as the region is one of the leading states in Germany's transition to renewable energy.

Underrepresented East
Germany has 16 federal states, with each state conducting its own election every five years. Saxony-Anhalt is one of the smallest states, which lies towards the eastern side. The state used to be under communist rule as the German Democratic Republic (GDR), till the 1990s, when the country was finally reunified after the fall of the Berlin Wall. However, eastern

states have often felt left out and ignored by the ruling ‘western’ establishment. Most former GDR citizens allege that they remain underrepresented at higher levels of government and in media and have less economic benefits than the western region.

The 2020 Annual Report on the Status of German Unity, released in 2021, stated that while the eastern region has tremendously improved its economic fortunes since reunification, it still has not caught up to western Germany's urban living standards. Eastern full-time employees earned about 86% of the western average. More importantly, the report talked about how there was still a notion of dissatisfaction among former GDR citizens, often shaped by the impact of the previous communist rule, the intense economic restructuring following reunification, as well as cultural changes.

The AfD has been quick to capture and exacerbate this sentiment; the party has been making steady gains in the eastern region for quite some time now. In 2017, it became the second-largest party in the region, winning 21.9% of the vote, while across Germany as a whole, it only had a vote share of 12.6%.

While Saxony-Anhalt is relatively small, with just 1.7 million voters out of 59 million voters nationwide, the result holds immense significance.

Significance of AfD win
Domestically, if the AfD is to form a government in the state, it will have over-arching powers regarding education and security issues. It will also get four seats in the upper house of the German Parliament, the Bundesrat, which represents all 16 states of the country. However, since the party falls short of an absolute majority, it is yet unclear how it expects to govern. While Mr. Siegmund had earlier remarked that the party would not engage in “games” such as a minority government, he has now said that he will be waiting with an “outstretched hand”. Moreover, the ‘firewall’ in German Parliament against allying with the AfD further complicates coalition talks.

The AfD's rise in the elections is also an indictment of the government of Chancellor Friedrich Merz. The cost of living crisis, stoked by inflation due to rising energy prices because of the war in West Asia and sanctions on Russia, has hit the state of Saxony-Anhalt quite hard. The people in the country gen-

erally feel that the Chancellor has not held up his promise to ensure fiscal discipline and revive the stagnating German economy. Mr. Merz has said that he was “deeply shocked” by the election results.

Internationally, the rise of the AfD spells trouble for the EU, as the party has been quite Euro-sceptic. It has often remarked that leaving the EU is necessary for its reforms to be implemented. At the same time, it has also said that a hard break would be counter-productive and that it would be better to ease into a looser organisation of European states. It has also advocated leaving the single currency system.

The party has also been severely critical of the support for Ukraine in the ongoing Russia-Ukraine war and has said that it will push back against sanctions on Russia, and revive energy deals and economic ties with Moscow.

Germany has two more state elections coming up, with the state of Mecklenburg-Vorpommern, also a former GDR state, and the capital city of Berlin both going to the polls on September 20. The AfD is leading the opinion polls in the former, with its current win bound to give local leadership in Mecklenburg-Vorpommern a major boost.

Mexican border shelters empty as Trump crackdown deters migrants

Reuters
CIUDAD JUAREZ

Migrant shelters along Mexico's northern border are emptying as fewer migrants head to the United States following President Donald Trump's immigration crackdown and mass deportation campaign.

For Salome Villena, an Ecuadorian migrant who once planned to cross into the U.S. with her husband and two children, aged 4 and 6, the shifting landscape of U.S. immigration policy meant change of those plans. Instead, the family has decided to remain in Ciudad Juarez, where they are among the few people still staying at a local shelter.



Ecuadorian migrant Salome Villena with her son Pablo in the dormitory at a shelter in Ciudad Juarez, Mexico. REUTERS

“Our intention was to cross into the United States, but because of what Trump did, we couldn't,” Ms. Villena said, referring to policies that have made legal migration routes more difficult to access.

Mr. Trump's return to

office abruptly closed off one of the main legal pathways migrants had used to enter the U.S., ending the CBP One app that allowed asylum seekers to schedule appointments at ports of entry. The move left thousands of migrants stranded

in border cities such as Ciudad Juarez and prompted Mexican authorities to prepare for a surge in deportees by opening emergency shelters.

Many of those facilities, however, remained largely empty as migrant arrivals fell and deportations were often carried out by air to southern Mexico or other countries.

Juan Fierro, who heads Ciudad Juarez's Good Samaritan shelter, said Mr. Trump's policies had sharply reduced the number of new arrivals.

“It's becoming increasingly complicated and difficult for people to reach Mexico's northern border and cross into the United States,” he said.

50th anniversary



Pouring respects: People hold portraits of late Communist leader Mao Zedong as they gather to pay tributes at the Bronze Statue Square in Shaoshan, China's central Hunan province, on Tuesday, a day before the 50th anniversary of the leader's death. AFP

An Iranian port city feels the pain of Washington’s tightening economic measures

Associated Press
BANDAR ABBAS

In the Iranian port city of Bandar Abbas on the Strait of Hormuz, a waterfront once busy with boats, trucks and workers has fallen quiet. It is a frontline of the economic pain that the United States now hopes to intensify after six months of war.

The Associated Press visited the city shaken by new U.S. airstrikes targeting coastal areas in the past week, and found anger along with growing anxiety about simply getting by as a U.S. blockade of Iranian ports continues.

A taxi driver, Hamid Hajizadeh, said he does not understand Americans. “They are heroes in movies, but here they killed people in schools, wedding ceremonies and other places. They bombed roads and bridges,” he said.

In this city of over 7,00,000 people, residents have a closer view than al-

most anyone of events on the strait that have seized global attention. They say their location has brought little but danger and discomfort over the past half year.

Mohammad Torabian works at the dock providing services to passengers. Before the war, he said, as many as 50 trucks carrying food and meat would unload there every day. Now, with the U.S. blockade that is aimed at keeping Iran from exporting its oil, much of the dock is empty.

“The business right now is terrible,” Mr. Torabian said. He estimated that about 500 people had been earning a living around the dock but “there is no job here.”

Constricting blockade
The fortunes of Bandar Abbas have long been tied to the sea and nearby Shahid Rajaee, one of Iran's largest commercial ports. Shahid Rajaee has the capacity to handle 100 million metric tonnes of cargo a year, ac-



A boy looks on as men manoeuvre motorboats through choppy waters off Bandar Abbas on Monday. AP

cording to a report in July by Iran's state-run IRNA news agency.

Iranian officials have sharply criticised the blockade, which the U.S. imposed in April and then imposed again after negotiations with Tehran on a path to end the war fell apart. Washington has since vowed more economic pressure over the strait, which is crucial to global shipping of oil, natu-

ral gas and related products.

Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Qalibaf, the lead negotiator in talks with the U.S. that collapsed, warned earlier this month that an escalation of the blockade would be met with a military response.

In Bandar Abbas, the effects are spreading through nearly every layer of the economy, from ships and dock workers to cus-

toms-clearing companies and shopkeepers.

Mahsa Shojaei, an accountant with a customs-clearing company, said much of its business before the war involved importing rice, tea and coffee from India and Pakistan.

Now, Ms. Shojaei estimated that 80% to 90% of her company's workload has disappeared. A business that might have handled around 100 customs-

clearance files during a certain period now processes only about 10, she said. At the same time, the cost of bringing cargo through customs has risen.

The economic damage has spread beyond the waterfront, especially as Iran's currency reaches record lows. In the retail markets, merchants said customers are disappearing as purchasing power deteriorates.

Mehrdad Jahangiri sells children's clothing at a shop that supports both his household and his father's. He said sales have fallen by about half compared to the same period last year.

“There are simply no customers,” Mr. Jahangiri said. “The market has become very quiet.”

The timing of the war was especially damaging for merchants. It began just before the Iranian New Year, Nowruz, traditionally one of the busiest shopping periods. Merchants rely on families to spend

more than during ordinary months. The war wiped out much of that expected business.

Lull in shopping
Now another crucial shopping period is slipping away. In the weeks before schools reopen later in September, families traditionally buy new clothes for their children. This year, Mr. Jahangiri said, the usual crowds have barely materialised.

The downturn has become severe enough that the shop sometimes falls behind on rent and accumulates debts in the market, something he said had not happened before.

“People's pockets are empty and incomes have fallen,” he said. Asked whether his family had been forced to cut back on everyday expenses, Mr. Jahangiri's answer was immediate. “Absolutely,” he said. “It has changed a lot.”

Other merchants have tried to adapt by offering discounts or allowing regu-

lar customers they trust to pay for goods in instalments.

For people earning their living directly from the sea, the problem goes beyond the disappearance of business. They also must consider how far they dare to venture offshore.

Abbas Golzanaei, a motorboat driver who transports passengers to ships and other nearby ports, said that before the war he travelled as far as 30 miles for work.

“Before the war, business was good,” Mr. Golzanaei said. “Now I can't go beyond seven or eight miles. The sea is not safe.”

That has left him with fewer passengers and less money. And “things are hard to find,” he said. “We have difficulty getting gasoline.”

Farther offshore, cargo vessels were silhouetted against the setting sun, suspended in uncertainty like Bandar Abbas itself, waiting to know when they can move again.

SEMIFINAL LINE-UP

India meets Bangladesh and Pakistan takes on Sri Lanka



India and Sri Lanka, who won all their matches in the league phase, topped their respective groups in the ongoing women's Asia Cup in Dubai. Pakistan and Bangladesh finished second. India will meet Bangladesh in the first semifinal on September 10 while Sri Lanka will clash with Pakistan the next day.

T20I RANKINGS

Smriti fifth among the batters, Deepti fifth in all-rounders' list



India opener Smriti Mandhana on Tuesday strengthened her position inside the top five of the ICC T20I rankings after her century against Hong Kong in the ongoing Asia Cup. Smriti is ranked fifth in the standings. Deepti Sharma moved to sixth in the bowlers' rankings and remained fifth among all-rounders.

PRIME FOCUS

The main goal is to win titles, ranking will follow: Rybakina



Number one is, of course, one of the goals. But I think the main focus is to win the titles and then the ranking will follow. We go match by match, but obviously we want to win tournaments — World No. 2 Elena Rybakina, who is assured of the top spot if she reaches the semifinals.

WELL-ROUNDED

I'm able to rely on a lot of different things to win points, feels Gauff



Coco Gauff has yet to lose a set so far in New York and has pointed to an improved serve as a source of confidence. "I'm able to rely on a lot of different things to win points in many different ways, and I think that gives me confidence," Gauff said after beating 14th seed Iva Jovic in the US Open on Monday.

East bowlers have South on the mat

The host loses six wickets for 242 and is still 466 runs in arrears at the end of day three; only Padikkal and Tilak offer some resistance

DULEEP TROPHY FINAL

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI

A disciplined bowling performance and the comfort of a huge first-innings total ensured East Zone tightened its stranglehold over South Zone on day three of the Duleep Trophy final at the MAC Stadium here.

Chasing 709, South needed more than a couple of batters to produce special knocks. Unfortunately, aside from Devdutt Padikkal (62, 104b, 4x4), none of the others showed much inclination to keep the contest alive.

In the final session on Tuesday, skipper Tilak Varma offered some resistance, remaining unbeaten on 56 (133b, 5x4), but it was akin to trying to keep a sinking boat afloat as his side finished on 242 for six, still 466 runs in arrears.

For East, Mohammed Shami and Mukesh Kumar took two wickets each. The former showed that he can still make the ball talk through both conventional and reverse swing with short yet incisive spells.

After losing opener Ricky Bhui early — caught down the leg-side off Mukesh Kumar — N. Jagadeesan and Padikkal added 60 runs for the second wicket.

The TN 'keeper-batter, though, threw away his start, slicing an innocuous wide delivery from left-arm spinner Shikhar Mohan to backward point.

Padikkal, fresh from twin centuries in the recently concluded Test se-



Master at work: Shami showed that he can still make the ball talk through conventional as well as reverse swing. R. RAGU

ries in Sri Lanka, was at his fluent best, cruising to a half-century. The south-paw looked set for another big one, until he flicked a leg-side half-volley from Mukesh down the square-leg fielder's throat, much to his disbelief.

Shami, in his second spell, attacked the stumps relentlessly and reaped the rewards through his trademark delivery that seamed off the pitch and trapped Shaik Rasheed plumb in front.

The 36-year-old then produced another peach from around the wicket that nipped away just enough to have R. Smaran caught behind, leaving South tottering at 174 for five.

Tilak and Shreyas Gopal then added 66 for the sixth wicket before the latter was dismissed in the final

over of the day. With East skipper Ishan Kishan already hinting that his team was not inclined to enforce the follow-on, the next two days could well be about going through the formalities before the coronation.

The scores: East Zone — 1st innings: 708 in 163 overs.

South Zone — 1st innings: Ricky Bhui c Kushagra b Mukesh 1, N. Jagadeesan c Abhimanyu b Shikhar 32, Devdutt Padikkal c sub (Denish) b Mukesh 62, Shaik Rasheed lbw b Shami 27, Tilak Varma (batting) 56, R. Smaran c Kushagra b Shami 23, Shreyas Gopal c & b Quraishi 26, C.V. Milind (batting) 2; Extras (b-8, nb-3, w-2): 13; Total (for six wkts. in 80 overs): 242.

Fall of wickets: 1-10, 2-70, 3-126, 4-129, 5-174, 6-240.

East Zone bowling: Shami 11-4-17-2, Mukesh 12-1-36-2, Quraishi 31-7-77-1, Abhijit 8-0-34-0, Shikhar 13-0-52-1, Sooryavanshi 4-0-10-0, Kishan 1-0-8-0.



Control: Mukesh refrained from going too full and wide. R. RAGU

‘Our plan was to let the batters take the risks’

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI

East Zone pacer Mukesh Kumar felt that there was enough on the surface for the quicks to keep the batters honest, provided they had the right tactics.

Despite bowling on a fresh MAC Stadium pitch on the opening day of the Duleep Trophy final, the South Zone fast bowlers were inconsistent and resorted to short-pitched stuff without much success.

In contrast, Mukesh and Mohammed Shami attacked the stumps and scalped four of the six wickets to fall on day three.

"I didn't pitch it too full here. If I had bowled full, it would have invited cover drives and similar shots. So, pulling the length back slightly to back-of-a-length on this red soil pitch [was important]. If you hit the deck hard and put effort into it, the ball kicks. We worked on that," said Mukesh.

The Bengal speedster also stressed the need to maintain the ball, especially on red-soil pitches where it could get scuffed easily. "Speaking for myself, the harder I pound the deck and hit the seam, the



Padikkal could not convert his start into a big one. R. RAGU

more the ball will kick, regardless of the wicket. The other part is working on the ball — applying sweat repeatedly, polishing it, and preparing it for reverse swing. We worked on that, and it gave us movement," he added.

On his plans for Devdutt Padikkal, Mukesh explained: "It was to bowl stump-to-stump because we knew he was coming after scoring two centuries in Sri Lanka. On wickets like this, if you offer width to batters, runs will leak. Our plan as fast bowlers was to stay as consistent as possible and bowl dot balls, letting them take the risks. They would try to force the pace and get out because they need to score runs."

Sabalenka subdues Noskova; van de Zandschulp survives

US OPEN

Agencies
NEW YORK

Top seed Aryna Sabalenka kept alive her hopes for a third straight US Open championship by fighting off Linda Noskova 7-6(1), 3-6, 7-6(10-7) on Tuesday in a thrilling quarterfinal match-up of Major champions.

Sabalenka finished off the match with a second-serve ace to turn back the Wimbledon champion and reach the semifinals at Flushing Meadows for the sixth straight year.

Sabalenka — who needed to win to maintain the No. 1 ranking — will face either No. 3 Jessica Pegula or No. 26 Emma Navarro on Thursday in the semifinals.

"What a battle," said Sabalenka. "I was pushing myself to the limit in this match especially in the third set. I honestly thought the match was over and that's what helped me to feel loose and go for my shots."

THE RESULTS

Men: Fourth round: 1-Zverev (Ger) bt Darderi (Ita) 6-2, 6-2, 7-6(3); van de Zandschulp (Ned) bt Gea (Fra) 3-6, 6-7(0), 7-6(7), 7-6(3), 6-4; Khachanov bt 14-Tien (USA) 7-5, 4-6, 6-7(6), 6-1, 6-4; 28-Blockx (Bel) bt 24-Cerundolo (Arg) 6-3, 4-6, 7-5, 7-5.

Women: Quarterfinals: 1-Sabalenka bt 6-Noskova (Cze) 7-6(1), 3-6, 7-6 (10-7). **Fourth round:** 4-Gauff (USA) bt 14-Jovic (USA) 6-1, 6-4; 2-Rybakina (Kaz) bt 13-Osaka (Jpn) 6-1, 6-4.

Noskova narrowly missed becoming the first woman since Serena Williams in 2016 to follow a title on the grass by reaching the final four on the hardcourts of New York.

Meanwhile on Monday, Dutch player Botic van de Zandschulp, who made waves in 2024 with a second-round upset of Carlos Alcaraz, saved a match point as he rallied from two sets down to beat France's Arthur Gea 3-6, 6-7(0), 7-6(7), 7-6(3), 6-4 in a match lasting five hours and 13 minutes.

He will play the French Open champion and top seed Alexander Zverev for

a place in the semifinals.

Zverev, who had been taken to five sets in his opening two matches, raced past 21st seed Luciano Darderi of Italy 6-2, 6-2, 7-6(3) on the Arthur Ashe Stadium court.

Alexander Blockx's dream debut continued with a gritty 6-3, 4-6, 7-5, 7-5 victory over Argentina's Francisco Cerundolo, which made the 21-year-old the first Belgian man to reach the US Open last eight.

He next faces Karen Khachanov after the Russian beat 14th-seeded American Learner Tien 7-5, 4-6, 6-7(6), 6-1, 6-4.

Rybakina cruises

In the women's section, World No. 2 Elena Rybakina, the reigning Australian Open champion, cruised past a hurting Naomi Osaka 6-1, 6-4 in just 66 minutes.

Fourth-seeded Coco Gauff reached the quarterfinals for the first time since she won the title in 2023, beating 18-year-old American compatriot Iva Jovic 6-1, 6-4.



Marathon effort: van de Zandschulp fought back from two sets down to beat Gea in a match that lasted more than five hours. GETTY IMAGES

Pranesh, Abhimanyu fumble in the end

GCL

P.K. Ajith Kumar
BENGALURU

At the Global Chess League, the margin for error can be thin. So thin, it doesn't exist.

M. Pranesh and Abhimanyu Mishra found that out in excruciating fashion at the Lalit Ashok on Tuesday.

Pranesh was in a completely winning position against Nihal Sarin, but he overlooked a simple check-mate and lost. Pranesh, however, had the consolation that his team, Cheq Mumbai Masters, won the match against Fyers American Gambits 11-6.

Abhimanyu's misfortune against Leon Mendonca proved costly, though. His team, PBG Alaskan Knights, lost to Ganges Grandmasters, 8-12. Abhimanyu was placed



Cruel twist: Abhimanyu's illegal move proved costly against Mendonca. SUDHAKARA JAIN

for a win in his game that would have given his team a match victory. However, when he promoted his pawn, in the time scramble, he put the queen on the wrong square after the capture.

Mendonca claimed it was an illegal move and the arbiter reset the clock, which left Abhimanyu to replay the capture and queening in one second. That wasn't humanly possible. So, he lost on time, as did his team.

The day's other matches weren't as dramatic, though there was plenty of excitement.

Four on top

At the end of it all, as many as four teams shared the top spot. At the half-way mark, defending champion Alpine APL Pipers — despite a 4-10 loss to Kings — Mumbai, Grandmasters and Gambits have all nine match points each.

Pipers and Mumbai are tied on games points, too —

47 each. Ganges is on 47 and Gambits, which has played a match more, on 52.

The results: Ganges Grandmasters bt PBG Alaskan Knights 12-8 (Nepomniachtchi bt Anand; Aronian lost to Arjun; Dominguez bt Erdogmus; Shuvalova bt Lagno; Tsoiakidou lost to Batsiashvili; Mendonca bt Abhimanyu).

Fyers American Gambits lost to Cheq Mumbai Masters 6-11 (Sindarov drew with Vachier-Lagrave; Nihal bt Pranesh; Dubov lost to Mamedyarov; Assaubayeva drew with Harika; Khademalsharieh lost to Yip; Maurizzi drew with Daneshvar).

Triveni Continental Kings bt Alpine APL Pipers 10-4 (Firouzja drew with Carlsen; Wei drew with Anish; Aravindh bt Vidit; Zhu drew with Divya; Kosteniuk drew with Humpy; Pranav bt Murzin).

Alaskan Knights lost to American Gambits 9-12 (Anand lost to Sindarov; Arjun lost to Nihal; Erdogmus bt Dubov; Lagno bt Assaubayeva; Batsiashvili bt Sarasadat; Abhimanyu lost to Maurizzi).

Gukesh needs to strike early against Sindarov in the title match: Nepo

P.K. Ajith Kumar
BENGALURU

Ian Nepomniachtchi has played the World chess championship match twice. Not even some of the world's strongest Grandmasters could make such a claim.

He knows how challenging the long series of games in a match for a player is. Looking ahead to this year's World title match, he feels the challenger Javokhir Sindarov starts as the favourite, but the reigning champion Gukesh still has chances.

"I wouldn't say it is something like 80-20 in favour of Sindarov, but it would be more like 65-35," Nepomniachtchi, who is here for the Tech Mahindra Global Chess League, told *The Hindu* on Tuesday.

"I believe it is important



All about momentum: Nepomniachtchi reckons whoever draws first blood would have the advantage. SUDHAKARA JAIN

who wins first. If Gukesh manages to win one at that stage, or at least not to lose, the match could become unclear because he gets some confidence. But, if Sindarov starts with a win, it could easily turn into a snowball."

Nepomniachtchi is glad to be back at the GCL after

missing out on the last two seasons. "I had some visa issues in 2024 and skipped the event last year," said the former World No. 2 from Russia who is playing for Ganges Grandmasters.

"I think the GCL has a fun format, and it is really fun for players. Sometimes, especially classical

I wouldn't say it is something like 80-20 in favour of Sindarov, but it would be more like 65-35

chess, it can be a little bit too controlled, and a bit boring for players as well as fans."

He believes the format at the GCL brings a lot of different imbalances. "You don't know the colour (of your pieces) before the game, at least for the first part," he points out. "Then we have the points system (four points for a win with black pieces). And it is nice to play in front of a respectable audience. Normally chess fans are quite elderly, and they just start snoring in the first row."

INBRIEF



Lazio rallies to beat Udinese in Serie A, keeps 100% record

Lazio fought back in the second half to score more than one goal for the first time this season and win 2-1 at Udinese in Serie A on Monday. Lazio joined Roma and Inter Milan as one of three teams with 100% record after three games. Lazio, which won its first two games 1-0, is third on goal difference.

The results: Serie A: Cagliari 1 (Maldini 29) bt Lecce 0; Udinese 1 (Karlstrom 49) lost to Lazio 2 (Frattesi 75, Gudmundsson 88).
LaLiga: Getafe 1 (Satriano 21) drew with Celta Vigo 1 (Starfelt 57); Elche 2 (Lemar 67, Nino 74) lost to Real Sociedad 3 (Ochieng 11, Herrera 31, Susic 90).

Aryan, Tanmay included in India under-19 cricket squads

Saurashtra's Aryan Savsani and Haryana's Tanmay Baloda have been added to India's under-19 squads for the upcoming home series against Australia, replacing Rohit Yadav in the one-day and multi-day squads respectively. The series will feature three one-dayers and two multi-day matches.

Tavish to helm Indian team at junior Davis Cup Finals

Tavish Pahwa, the reigning National u-18 and u-16 champion, will lead India in the junior Davis Cup Finals to be held in Cairo from November 2 to 8, the AITA has announced. Ribhav Saroha and Hruthik Katakam are the other two members of the team which will be coached by KSLTA's Rana Banerjee.

Mumbai City signs Cirkovic; Punjab FC ropes in Raposo

Mumbai City FC has strengthened its squad ahead of the 2026-27 ISL season with the signing of Serbian defender Lazar Cirkovic on a one-year deal, while Punjab FC has roped in Brazilian forward Diego Henrique Oliveira Raposo. Raposo last appeared for Bulgarian top-division team FC Lokomotiv Sofia, making 19 appearances in the league. This is Punjab FC's fourth foreign signing of the season.

Lawson to join Verstappen as a Red Bull driver again

For a third consecutive race, Liam Lawson will join Max Verstappen as a Red Bull driver while Isack Hadjar recovers from a broken wrist, the Formula One team announced on Monday. Hadjar was injured during the summer break and still has not fully recovered.

'Expectations put you in the future but it's crucial to stay in the present'

SHOOTING

Uthra Ganesan
NEW DELHI

Shooting is perhaps the one Indian sport that garners maximum spotlight at the Asian Games, and rightly so. At the previous edition in 2023, Indian shooters returned with an impressive haul of 22 medals and the expectations this time around are expectedly high. For the men working on the men and women holding the rifles and pistols, however, performances take precedence over expectations.

"Our focus is always on delivering good performances but that doesn't only mean medals which also depends on what others do. We know the strengths and weaknesses of our athletes and we are working on developing the former and reducing the latter.

"If every athlete is able to reach closer to his/her potential, that would be a satisfactory moment and if we are able to do that, it



Pierre Beauchamp and Ronak Pandit. R.V. MOORTHY

should translate into a lot of smiles and a lot of medals," pistol coach and High Performance Manager Ronak Pandit told *The Hindu* at the squad's preparatory camp at the MP Shooting Academy in Bhopal.

NRAI High Performance Director Pierre Beauchamp added that the important thing was to stay in the present. "Expectations put you in the future. And we need to be in the present. If you go back to the previous Asian Games, you're in the past.

"We only talk about the present, we don't talk about future expectations. We focus on helping them manage their process in the best possible way, have the coping strategies effective for performance under



pressure.

"We're supplying education, we're strong on sports science support. But at the end of the day, it's the athlete that's on the line. He or she needs to believe in themselves. And if they believe in themselves, usually good things happen," he smiled.

Pandit agreed. "At the end of the day, you have to stay in the present, stay focused on the shot in your barrel in that moment. You have to remember your process and the steps you need to follow, what you need to do to release that shot well. At the end of the day, your gun doesn't know who's firing it, where it is being fired, the occasion it is being fired. It is going to shoot where you point the barrel."

Pakistan rolls the dice in search of consolation win

Agence France-Presse
BIRMINGHAM

Pakistan will try to salvage something from the wreckage of a woeful tour of England with an upset victory in the third Test starting on Wednesday.

Mammoth defeats in the opening two encounters mean that Pakistan has already lost the three-match series.

But its response to a 194-run loss in the second Test at Lord's – which followed an innings reverse in the series opener at Headingley – surprised even long-standing observers of Pakistan's often volatile cricket scene.

The Pakistan Cricket Board (PCB) took the extraordinary step of sending seven players home and calling up another seven, five of whom are uncapped at Test level.

At the same time, the PCB also sacked Test coach Sarfaraz Ahmed and bowling chief Umar Gul, replacing them with Pakistan white-ball counterparts



Focus: Babar would hope to keep the white noise out and focus on playing good cricket. REUTERS

The challenge for England is to maintain the professionalism – a sharp contrast to the extravagances at the end of the Bazball era

Mike Hesson and Ashley Noffke.

England captain Joe Root, second in Test cricket's list of all-time run-scorers, said after Lord's that a combination of seam-friendly pitches, overcast skies and responsive crick-

et balls had created a "perfect storm" for batters on both sides.

Professionalism

The challenge for the England team is to maintain the professionalism – a sharp contrast to the extravagances at the end of the Bazball era – that has carried it to a first Test series win in over a year by rounding off Root's first series back in charge with a whitewash.

Indian Railways in the fray in FIBA-WBLA

BASKETBALL

K. Keerthivasan
CHENNAI

Reigning National champion Indian Railways will be competing in the third edition of Asia's premier annual competition for women's basketball clubs (FIBA-Women's Basketball League Asia-WBLA) to be held at the Sree Kanteerava Stadium in Bengaluru from October 20 to 25. Railways will take on Denso Iris (Japan) in its first match on October 21. This is the first time a team from India is taking part in WBLA.

Six teams have been divided into two groups according to the FIBA World Ranking for Women. The Group Phase, to be held on October 20-22, will be played in a single round-robin format. The top two teams from each group will compete in the knockout crossover semifinals, while the teams that will finish third in their groups will play in a Classification 5-6. These games will be played on October 24 followed by the final on October 25. "Our team looks good. We have to start the preparatory camp which will either be in Telangana or Bengaluru. It's quite a tough pool we are in with clubs from Korea and Japan. We will give a tough fight and hope for the best," P. Anitha, head coach of the Indian team told *The Hindu* here on Tuesday.

The groups:
A: Sichuan Yuanda Meile (China); Akari Sparks (Philippines); Cathay Life Tigers (Taipei); **B:** Denso Iris (Japan); KB Stars (Korea); Indian Railways.

Indian men put it across South Korea



Good going: India is within touching distance of a semifinal berth. HOCKEY INDIA

JUNIOR ASIA CUP

Press Trust of India
MOQI (CHINA)

Captain Anmol Ekka struck twice as the Indian junior men's hockey team ripped through South Korea's defence in a late surge for a 7-3 victory that left it within touching distance of a semifinal berth in the Junior Asia Cup on Tuesday.

The victory took India's tally to seven points from three matches, including two wins and a draw. India will face Taiwan in its last pool match on Wednesday, knowing a victory will seal a place in the last-four stage.

Anmol once again shone for India, scoring twice to take his tournament tally to eight goals.

India took the lead in the fifth minute when Anmol converted a penalty corner. However, South Korea responded with Dohyeon Choi finding the back of the net from a penalty corner in the very next minute.

Lovenoor Singh put India back in front with a field goal in the 18th minute, but South Korea once again found a quick response. Hyoguk Yoo scored from a penalty corner within the next 60 seconds

Indian women enter the quarterfinals

Press Trust of India
MOQI (CHINA)

The Indian junior women's hockey team continued its dominant run at the Asia Cup, cruising to a commanding 7-0 victory over Japan in its third Elite pool match to secure a place in the quarterfinals, here on Tuesday.

With nine points from three outings, India currently sits at the top. It will face China on Wednesday in the team's final pool match, which will determine the top position in the pool. China currently has six points from two matches.

to make it 2-2. India, however, ensured it carried the advantage into the half-time break. Ajeet Yadav struck in the 20th minute to restore India's one-goal cushion and give it a 3-2 lead at the break.

Yoo was once again at the heart of South Korea's attacking effort, scoring his second goal just six minutes into the third quarter, which brought the Koreans level for the third time at 3-3.

Prabhdheep Singh found the breakthrough towards the end of the third quarter, restoring India's lead at 4-3 in the 42nd minute, giving his side the momentum heading into the final 15 minutes.

India eventually broke through with a remarkable three-goal burst in the space of just three minutes. Gursewak Singh extended India's advantage in the 55th minute before Anmol struck again a minute later off a penalty corner to make it 6-3. Aryan Xess then completed the decisive spell in the 58th minute as India's relentless pressure produced a seventh goal for a 7-3 win.

The result: India 7 (Anmol 5, 56, Lovenoor 18, Ajeet 20, Prabhdheep 42, Gursewak Singh 55, Aryan Xess 58) bt South Korea 3 (Dohyeon Choi 6, Hyoguk Yoo 19, 36).

Krishna Sharma found the back of the net in the fifth minute for a 1-0 lead. India doubled its advantage in the ninth minute with a penalty stroke conversion by Supriya.

India added a third just before the end of the opening quarter. Purnima Yadav scored a field goal in the 14th minute as India finished the first quarter with a 3-0 lead.

India then shifted the gears, scoring three goals in the space of five minutes.

The result: India 7 (Krishna 5, Supriya 9, Purnima 14, 46, Geeta 41, 45, Sanika 50) bt Japan 0.



Savita stresses on the importance of staying in the present in the upcoming continental show-piece, while they are keen to build on the positives and end a 44-year wait.